

Where the Rainbow Ends: Beneath the Neon

Complete Narrative & Technical Design Document

1. Project Overview

Beneath the Neon is a cyberpunk visual novel set in an alternate-history, fragmented Japan. In this timeline, Tokyo is no longer the proud capital of a unified nation. Instead, it has morphed into a semi-autonomous economic zone maintained collectively by megacorporations, intrusive surveillance networks, endless consumer entertainment, and runaway technological industries.

The player takes on the role of **Character A**, a mid-level technical engineer at a dominant MegaCorp. He lives on the comfortable, middle-class "surface" of the metropolis: stable employment, corporate housing, automated commutes, state-of-the-art tech, and pristine, sanitised commercial sectors. However, during a night out at the Neon Pub, he crosses paths with **Character B**, a youth from the lower class. B has no official identity or steady job, surviving entirely on odd jobs, salvaged e-waste, black market transactions, and temporary shelters.

The core gameplay experience centers on perspective shift: players initially witness a prosperous, highly efficient, and dazzling Tokyo. As the narrative progresses, they peel back the neon layers to discover the class rigidity, omnipresent surveillance, spiritual emptiness, and discarded human beings hiding just beneath the city's glossy facade.

The project's physical and narrative architecture is anchored on this vertical divide:

- **"Above Ground" (The Surface):** Neon skyscrapers, automated bullet trains, holographic advertisements, and artificial cleanliness.
- **"Below Ground" (Beneath):** Flooded subway tunnels, illegal trading hubs, ruined shelters, gang-controlled sectors, homeless encampments, and cybernetic junkyards.

2. Core Message

The Surface

- Tokyo stands as the undisputed global epicenter of electronic engineering and consumer technology.
- The city presents itself as bright, orderly, and impeccably efficient—boasting climbing GDPs, rising productivity, and ceaseless technological breakthroughs.

Beneath the Surface

- Lower-class residents are systematically stripped of stable legal identities and upward mobility.
- The middle class, while secure with housing and stable salaries, is hollowed out by mind-numbing repetition, relentless corporate surveillance, and emotional desensitization.

Core Theme

"A city can look successful while the people inside it are quietly breaking."

Or, aligned precisely with the hackathon motif:

"The project reveals the social and emotional decay hidden beneath the surface of a prosperous cyberpunk city."

The core concept highlights that while this alternate Japan appears shiny, growing, and productive on paper, it is rotting from within. The lower class is crushed by extreme wealth disparities and rigid systemic walls, while the middle class suffers from spiritual starvation, mechanical routines, and systemic dehumanization. This fits the "Beneath the Surface" theme perfectly—exploring hidden truths not just on a literal geological level, but through complex social systems and character psychology.

3. Genre and Format

- **Genre:** Cyberpunk Visual Novel / Interactive Narrative Experience
- **Core Mechanic:** Players progress through text, making key decisions at critical crossroads. The game uses a custom **split-screen dialogue system**:

Left Side of Screen

Spoken Words: What the character says out loud.

Right Side of Screen

Internal Thoughts: What the character is actually thinking.

This mechanic directly mirrors the thematic focus: players don't just see the "surface language" of polite society; they are forced to witness the "unspoken truth beneath."

4. Worldbuilding

4.1 Alternate History Background

In this timeline, post-WWII Japan did not experience rapid reconstruction and reunification. Instead, devastated by prolonged bombings, naval blockades, mass famine, and internal systemic collapse, the country was partitioned into several Allied occupation zones. Japan ceased to exist as a unified sovereign state.

The key divided territories include:

Region	Governing Characteristics
Kantō Administrative Zone	Centered around Tokyo; heavily dominated by American corporate and financial interests.
Northern Reconstruction Republic	Spanning Hokkaido and Northern Tōhoku; governed under Soviet influence.
Kansai Federation	Comprising Osaka, Kyoto, and Kobe; highly industrialized but politically volatile.
Western Maritime Authority	Encompassing Hiroshima, Kyushu, and naval sectors; controlled by a joint multinational commission.
Buffer Territories	Highly militarized border buffer zones and lawless, ruined wilderness.

Following the failed reunification talks of 1953, border cities, black markets, cross-border smuggling, and corporate mercenaries stepped in to fill the geopolitical vacuum.

4.2 Rise of the Megacorps

During the late 1950s, the fractured territories faced severe crises: ruined infrastructure, hyperinflation, crashing birth rates, and rampant organized crime. Weak administrative governments, desperate to maintain basic civic order, gradually outsourced public utilities and state functions to massive industrial conglomerates.

Today, these megacorporations completely control:

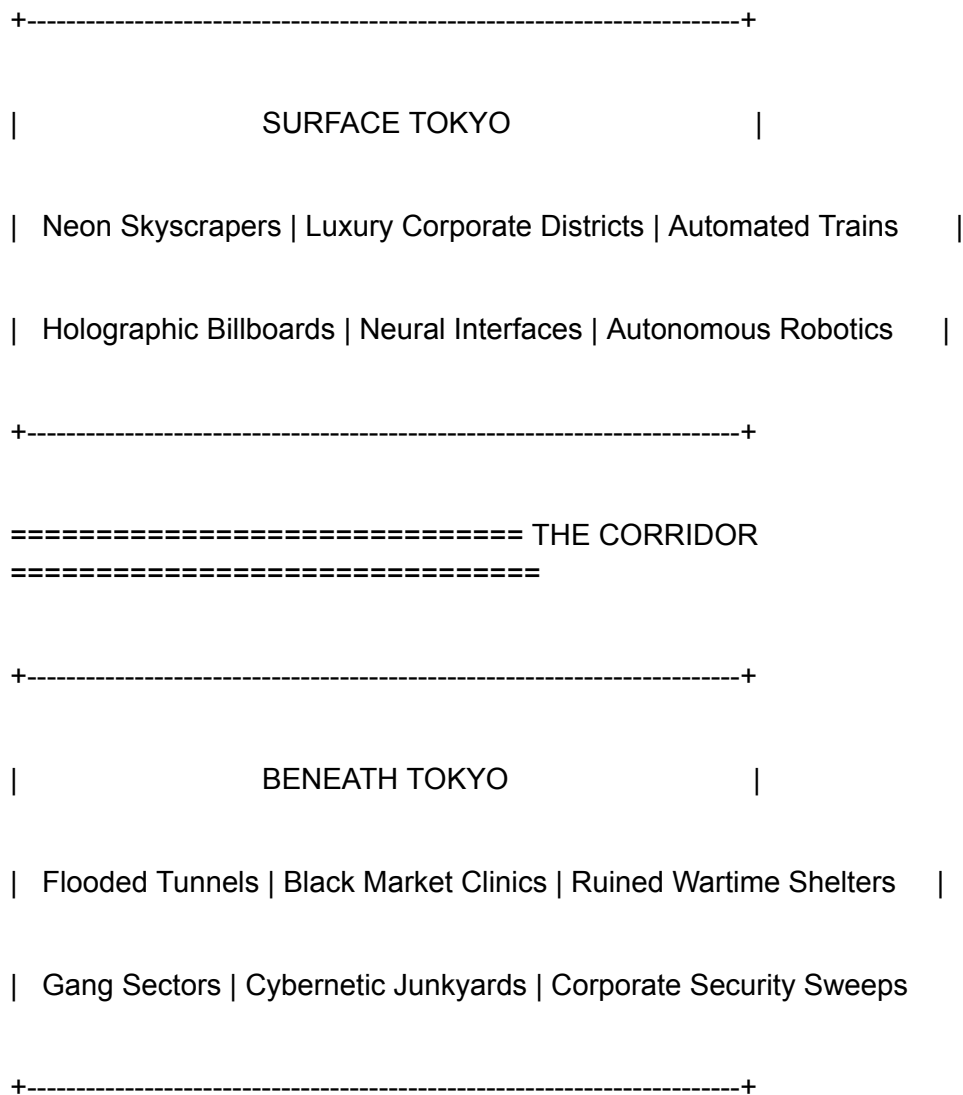
- Public transportation and logistics
- Consumer electronics and neural-tech manufacturing
- Private military and municipal security

- Corporate housing complexes
- Rationing and food distribution
- Schools, universities, and hospitals
- Border checkpoints and customs
- Data networks and surveillance sweeps

By 1977, corporate power had entirely eclipsed traditional governance. The ultra-wealthy reside in sterile, high-rise luxury towers, while the underclass is compressed beneath elevated highways, inside flooded subway stations, and within wartime ruins. Tokyo has officially become the most unequal city on Earth.

4.3 The Tokyo Corridor

In 1981, a consortium of dominant corporations unified their municipal territories to form a massive, semi-independent economic zone known colloquially as **The Tokyo Corridor**. It is a hyper-commercialized, neon-soaked, and heavily monitored urban sprawl.



This vertical polarity serves as the primary visual and structural metaphor: the higher you go, the cleaner, brighter, and more efficient the world appears; the lower you descend, the damper, more chaotic, hazardous, and intensely human it becomes.

5. Main Characters

Character A — The Corporate Engineer

- **Base Concept:** A is a mid-level systems engineer for a prominent MegaCorp. He enjoys solid middle-class standing: stable employment, valid corporate citizenship, dedicated housing, and decent social privileges. However, trapped in a loop of identical daily schedules, he suffers from profound alienation and a fading sense of self. He is highly observant, intellectual, and technical, but uses his analytical mindset as a defensive shield to mask sheer existential exhaustion.
- **Key Traits:** Introverted, technical, observant, emotionally restrained, intellectually defensive, highly functional yet internally burnt out, masking fatigue behind cold, rational jargon.
- **The Surface Persona:** An exemplary product of the city's success: employed, documented, housed, paid, and recognized as a "valid citizen" with access to pristine business sectors.
- **The Reality Beneath:** Deeply alienated. He has zero meaningful relationships, filters all raw emotions through clinical analysis, harbors no hopes for the future, operates like a clockwork gear, and is entirely disconnected from his own desires.
- **Character Role:** Represents *the emptiness hidden beneath middle-class stability*.

Character B — The Drifter

- **Base Concept:** B is a street-level survivor, scraping by on odd jobs, scavenged tech, black-market trades, and temporary squatted shelters. He is highly expressive, energetic, and socially versatile. However, this apparent "freedom" is a desperate, exhausting coping mechanism for a life completely devoid of legal protections, stable resources, or a predictable future.
- **Key Traits:** Extroverted, energetic, socially adaptive, impulsive, uses humor defensively, blind to his own emotional friction, outwardly liberated but inwardly volatile.
- **The Surface Persona:** How A initially perceives him: carefree, vibrant, direct, untamed by corporate schedules, and seemingly more "alive" than anyone in the upper districts.
- **The Reality Beneath:** Displaced and precarious. He has no physical home, lacks legal identification, is constantly hunted by corporate private security, has zero path toward social elevation, and cracks jokes to suppress deep-seated terror and despair.
- **Character Role:** Represents *the insecurity hidden beneath apparent freedom*.

6. Character Relationship

The narrative avoids the tired tropes of "middle-class savior rescues lower-class victim" or a lighthearted buddy comedy. Instead, it is built on a mutual, layered misunderstanding:

[Character A] <===== Misunderstands =====> [Character B]

(Envy's B's apparent freedom &

(Envy's A's security, housing,

untamed vitality)

& systemic protection)

\\

//

\\===== Realize both are trapped by the =====//

same corporate apparatus in different ways.

- **A's Misconception:** A interprets B's high energy and street smarts as true freedom—possessing the soul and agency that A lost to corporate life.
- **B's Misconception:** B views A's high-tech apartment and corporate credential as absolute safety—possessing the stability and choices B has never known.
- **The Truth:** A has systemic identity but no vitality. B has freedom of movement but no safety. One is swallowed whole by the corporate machine; the other is spat out as waste. Neither is truly free.

7. Plot Outline

Prologue — Surface of Tokyo

The story opens not with A's misery, but with Tokyo's overwhelming, high-tech success.

- **The Surface:** The player is greeted with climbing GDP statistics, sleek automated trains gliding past towering holographic neon displays, advertisements for advanced neural interfaces, and glossy corporate propaganda emphasizing municipal harmony.
- **The Beneath:** The camera slowly pans down to reveal subtle, jarring anomalies. Corporate security officers aggressively sweep undocumented "vagrancies" from public sight; the state news sanitizes this as "routine urban sanitation." Meanwhile, A sits in a crowded subway train, staring blankly into the dark tunnel ahead.
- **Objective:** Establish the bright, perfect facade before introducing the rot beneath.

Act I — Neon Pub

Prompted by a mandatory "corporate wellness recommendation," or perhaps in a desperate attempt to prove to himself that he can still function socially, A visits the high-end Neon Pub.

- The pub is a sensory overload: pounding synth beats, floating holographic advertisements, overpriced synthetic drinks, and corporate workers desperately pretending to enjoy themselves while smugglers and gang members operate in the shadows. Everyone is putting on an act.
- Unable to join in, A retreats outside to clear his head. In the damp alleyways, B is quietly hunting through commercial disposal bins for discarded high-tech scrap: expired corporate access tags, fried processing chips, half-empty synth-drink cartridges, and thrown-away neural adapters. Their eyes meet.
- **Narrative Function:** Establish their first contact. B leaves a sharp, baffling impression on A, who immediately misreads B as an emblem of authentic freedom.

Act II — Subway / Street Encounter

Overwhelmed by the artificiality of the pub, A departs toward the transit station. Along the dark streets, he silently compares his numb existence to B's chaotic, yet seemingly vibrant life.

Near the subway entrance, they cross paths again. B has made a discovery: he found A's corporate ID card, which A dropped outside the pub.

- For A, the card is his entire life—his apartment access, transit pass, and proof of legal existence.
- For B, the card is a priceless, dangerous golden ticket into the secure upper districts.
- Before they can negotiate, a sudden corporate security sweep is declared. Armed guards begin scanning civilians for registration. Knowing B will be arrested or worse, A must make a crucial choice: shield B by claiming they are together, or abandon him to save himself.
- **Narrative Function:** Expose the brutality of the classification system and corporate security. A is forced to actively intervene, providing a natural bridge to bring B back to his private quarters.

Act III — Apartment Conversation

Trapped by a torrential downpour, transit shutdown, and intensive security patrols, A brings B back to his corporate apartment.

- For A, the apartment is a sterile, claustrophobic prison of routine.
- For B, the apartment is an unimaginable luxury—it has a lock, a bed, running hot water, electricity, and a ceiling that doesn't leak acid rain.

The dialogue explores three core contrasts:

1. **Work:** A's job is stable but soul-crushing; B's work is free but entirely precarious.

2. **Identity:** A has an official ID but feels invisible; B has no official ID and is virtually non-existent in the eyes of the law.
3. **Sleep:** A has a comfortable bed but suffers from severe insomnia; B can sleep on cold concrete, but is never safe enough to truly rest.
- **Objective:** Rather than forming an instant bond, the dialogue begins to break down their romanticized projections of each other.

Act IV — One Month Later

Both characters return to their respective realities. They do not meet for a full month. This is presented as a rapid, rhythmic montage contrasting their lives:

- **A's Routine:** Wake $\rightarrow$ biometric scan $\rightarrow$ repetitive desk work $\rightarrow$ productivity assessment $\rightarrow$ silent commute $\rightarrow$ dim apartment $\rightarrow$ repeat.
- **B's Routine:** Scavenge parts $\rightarrow$ dodge corporate guards $\rightarrow$ sleep on subway grates $\rightarrow$ trade scraps $\rightarrow$ swap jokes with strangers $\rightarrow$ vanish into the underground.

Across the bottom of the screen, corporate news tickers scroll relentlessly:

- *"Tokyo Corridor Productivity Reaches All-Time High."*
- *"Public Satisfaction Metrics Remain Exceptionally Stable."*
- *"Urban Sanitation Sweeps Completed Successfully."*
- *"Unregistered Populations Reduced by 14%."*
- **Objective:** Emphasize that as corporate statistics optimize, human lives are systematically erased.

Act V — Rainy Riverbank

Desperate to escape the claustrophobic confinement of his corporate life, A takes a late-night walk along a concrete flood canal. He discovers B standing on the outer ledge of a rusted bridge over the dark, polluted river.

Note: To keep the narrative subtle and poignant for a hackathon demo, this should not be portrayed as an overt, sensationalized suicide scene.

- B is standing over the edge, staring at the pitch-black water.
- The rain is heavy.
- A is unsure if B is merely zoning out, playing a dangerous game, or genuinely contemplating stepping off.
- They share their final, most honest conversation.

The focus is not on a dramatic physical rescue, but an intellectual and emotional unmasking: they finally see each other without the surface illusion. A no longer envies B's chaotic survival, and B no longer envies A's gilded cage. They recognize each other as fellow casualties of the same great machine.

Ending — Ambiguous Resolution

The narrative resolves on an open-ended, poignant note:

- **Ending A (Quiet Survival):** B climbs down from the ledge. The two walk silently through the rain toward the first morning train. The city remains unbroken, but they are no longer entirely alone in the dark.
- **Ending B (Reflection):** The camera slowly pans down to the dark river, neon billboards reflecting off the polluted current. The player is left unsure if B stepped off, listening only to A's quiet, lingering internal monologue.
- **Ending C (The Machine Grinds On):** The screen cuts abruptly to a bright corporate broadcast: *"Tokyo Corridor Economic Confidence Reaches Record Highs."* The screen fades to black. The city does not care about individual sorrow.

8. Scene Settings

Scene 0 — Prologue: Surface of Tokyo

- **Time:** 08:00 PM
- **Objective:** Introduce the polished, high-tech corporate illusion.
- **Visual Assets:** Aerial city shots, sparkling neon skylines, massive holographic koi swimming through glass towers, automated bullet trains, and sleek advertisements.
- **The Beneath Hints:** Silent, exhausted faces on the train; armed security guards shoving a homeless man into an unmarked van; bureaucratic propaganda voiceovers.

Scene A — The Apartment

- **Time:** 02:00 AM
- **Objective:** Highlight A's actual, isolated existence.
- **Visual Assets:** A tiny, cramped apartment where a single bed, workstation, and kitchenette overlap. Lit only by dim yellow task lights and the soft, cold blue hum of computer monitors.
- **The Beneath:** Represents the mechanical storage pods designed to hold corporate labor. Safe, yet suffocatingly lonely.

Scene B — The Neon Pub

- **Time:** 10:00 PM
- **Objective:** Contrast synthetic pleasure with deep social exhaustion.
- **Visual Assets:** Tucked beneath concrete overpasses and glowing billboards. Packed with burnt-out corporate staff, underground couriers, and shady dealers. Filled with smoke, cybernetic steam, and aggressive neon hues.
- **The Beneath:** Corporate employees drink to forget; lower-class outcasts search the garbage bins for survival.

Scene C — The Rainy Riverbank

- **Time:** 03:00 AM

- **Objective:** The raw, unmasked climax.
- **Visual Assets:** A concrete canal flanked by monolithic industrial blocks. Acid rain falls on rusted handrails and cracked pavement. It is quiet, wet, and isolated from the sparkling city center.
- **The Beneath:** Raw pollution, cold wind, and the heavy, undeniable weight of marginalization.

Scene D — Subway Transit

- **Time:** 06:00 PM / Peak Hours
- **Objective:** Order coexisting with systemic decay.
- **Visual Assets:** Packed train platforms, silent commuters, flickering fluorescent tubes, flashing identity scanners, and relentless corporate alerts.
- **The Beneath:** Relentless surveillance, random security checkpoints, and exhausted crowds functioning like fuel for the city's engine.

9. Gameplay & Interactive Design

9.1 Gameplay Overview

Beneath the Neon is a narrative-focused visual novel developed in Ren'Py. The player's primary engagement is reading, comparing spoken words with private thoughts, and making critical decisions at narrative junctions. The game prioritizes high narrative polish and thematic consistency over branching maps.

9.2 Core Player Experience Flow

1. **The Facade (Cinematic):** The player is seduced by the flawless, high-tech aesthetic of the Tokyo Corridor.
2. **The Cracks (Observation):** Through A's eyes, the player begins detecting anomalies—surveillance overreach, the clearing of "unregistered" people, and the profound exhaustion of the populace.
3. **The Depth (Connection):** Through the split-screen dialogue system, players witness the wide chasm between what A and B say out loud versus what they actually feel inside.

9.3 The Split-Screen Dialogue System

The primary gameplay mechanic is the split-screen dialogue layout. The screen divides to expose the contrast between public masks and private realities:

+-----+-----+

| SPOKEN WORDS | INTERNAL THOUGHTS |

	A: "Just one drink."		A: (He didn't want a drink. He	
			just wanted proof that he was	
			still passably alive.)	
	B: "Must be nice, having a room."		B: (Don't sound jealous. Keep it	
			light. Make it a joke.)	
	A: "I'm fine."		A: (The word was empty. He had	
			said it so often it no longer	
			possessed meaning.)	
+-----+-----+				

9.4 Choice Design

Choices are sparse but highly impactful, focusing on character development rather than wild plot branching:

- How A chooses to perceive B's lifestyle (envy vs. pity).
- Whether A takes personal risks to protect B from security networks.
- The emotional tone and walls maintained during their conversations.
- These choices accumulate to determine the final ending and the psychological state of both characters.

9.5 Hidden Variable Tracking

Four hidden variables run beneath the script to shape dialogue variations:

Variable	Function
<code>trust</code>	Measures how willing A and B are to drop their defenses and speak raw truth.
<code>projection</code>	Tracks how much they continue to romanticize and misunderstand each other's lives.
<code>noise</code>	Tracks urban stress, surveillance pressure, and mental exhaustion.
<code>masking</code>	Tracks A's tendency to hide behind cold, intellectual, and rational jargon.

10. Technical Architecture (Ren'Py Implementation)

10.1 Engine Choice

We are targeting **Ren'Py** for a downloadable desktop release. Ren'Py is highly specialized for visual novels, offering built-in save/load systems, robust screen language, custom variable tracking, and fast prototyping capabilities.

10.2 Recommended Directory Structure

BeneathTheNeon/

├── game/

| ├── script.rpy # Main script and scene flow

| ├── characters.rpy # Character and side-image definitions

| ├── screens.rpy # UI, split-screen layouts, news tickers

| ├── variables.rpy # Global variables and tracking setups

- | |— dialogue_variants.rpy # Dynamic dialogue variant logic

- | |— audio.rpy # Audio definitions and channels

- | |— gui.rpy # Standard GUI configuration

- | |— images/

- | | |— backgrounds/ # bg_tokyo_surface, bg_apartment, bg_riverbank, etc.

- | | |— characters/ # Sprites (a_neutral, a_tired, b_smirk, b_quiet, etc.)

- | | |— ui/ # Custom textboxes and ticker graphics

- | |— audio/ # SFX and music files (rain_loop, pub_synth, etc.)

- | |— fonts/ # Custom cyberpunk UI typography

- |— README.md # Documentation for developers/judges

- |— credits.md # Asset attribution and tools used

10.3 Core Script Outline (**script.rpy**)

label start:

 \$ renpy.block_say(True)

 jump prologue_surface

label prologue_surface:

Cinematic introduction: Establish Tokyo Corridor's pristine surface

scene bg_tokyo_surface with fade

play music corporate_jingle loop

show screen news_ticker("TOKYO CORRIDOR ECONOMIC PERFORMANCE
EXCEEDS PROJECTIONS...")

"SYSTEM" "Welcome to the Tokyo Corridor. Your wellness is monitored."

hide screen news_ticker

jump neon_pub

label neon_pub:

A attempts to socialize, meets B scavenging outside

scene bg_neon_pub with fade

play music neon_pub_synth loop

\$ dual_line("A", "Just one drink.", "He did not want a drink. He wanted proof that he could
still pass as alive.")

jump subway_checkpoint

label subway_checkpoint:

Identity sweep occurs; B holds A's dropped ID card

scene bg_subway with fade

play music subway_hum loop

"SECURITY" "Prepare citizen credentials for immediate biometric scanning."

menu:

"Claim B is with you (Requires Risk)":

\$ trust += 1

\$ projection -= 1

\$ noise += 1

jump help_b

"Demand your ID card back immediately":

\$ masking += 1

jump demand_id

"Walk away and pretend you don't know him":

\$ trust -= 1

\$ noise += 1

jump ignore_b

label apartment_conversation:

Rainy, quiet dialogue inside A's living pod

scene bg_apartment with fade

play music rain_loop loop

if trust >= 2:

 jump apartment_high_trust

else:

 jump apartment_low_trust

label one_month_montage:

 # Cinematic sequence illustrating separate repetitive routines

 jump riverbank

label riverbank:

 # Final conversation on the edge of the river canal

 scene bg_riverbank with fade

 play music riverbank_rain loop

 jump ending

label ending:


```
# Resolve based on trust, projection, and masking variables
```

```
"Fade to Black."
```

```
return
```

10.4 Screen Definition: Split-Screen Dialogue (**screens.rpy**)

```
screen dual_dialogue(speaker, spoken, thought):
```

```
# Left Box: Spoken Words
```

```
frame:
```

```
    xalign 0.05
```

```
    yalign 0.75
```

```
    xsize 600
```

```
    ysize 240
```

```
    background "images/ui/textbox_left.png"
```

```
    padding (20, 20)
```

```
    vbox:
```

```
        spacing 10
```

```
        text "[speaker] (Spoken)" size 20 color "#00ffff" bold True
```

```
text "[spoken]" size 24 color "#ffffff"
```

```
# Right Box: Internal Thoughts
```

```
frame:
```

```
    xalign 0.95
```

```
    yalign 0.75
```

```
    xsize 600
```

```
    ysize 240
```

```
    background "images/ui/textbox_right.png"
```

```
    padding (20, 20)
```

```
    vbox:
```

```
        spacing 10
```

```
        text "(Thoughts)" size 20 color "#ff00ff" bold True
```

```
        text "[thought]" size 22 color "#e0a0e0" italic True
```

10.5 Python Wrapper for Split-Screen Calls

To call this custom screen cleanly inside your standard script flow, define this Python helper in your initialization blocks:

init python:

```
def dual_line(speaker, spoken, thought):  
  
    renpy.call_screen("dual_dialogue", speaker=speaker, spoken=spoken,  
thought=thought)
```

This lets you write simple, elegant script lines like:

```
$ dual_line("B", "Must be nice, having a room.", "Don't sound jealous. Make it a joke.")
```

10.6 Dynamic Dialogue Variant System (**dialogue_variants.rpy**)

To make replay playthroughs feel responsive without relying on unpredictable runtime AI APIs, use pre-authored variations that trigger based on variables:

init python:

```
import random
```

```
def get_b_checkpoint_dialogue():
```

```
    high_trust_lines = [  
  
        "You tower people always drop your expensive credentials.",  
  
        "Relax, friend. I was just keeping your card dry."  
  
    ]
```

```
    low_trust_lines = [  
  
        "You tower people always drop your expensive credentials.",  
  
        "Relax, friend. I was just keeping your card dry."  
  
    ]
```

"Nice ID. Wonder how much corporate security would pay to buy it back?",

"You dropped your life in the alley. Lucky for you, I found it."

]

if trust >= 1:

 return random.choice(high_trust_lines)

else:

 return random.choice(low_trust_lines)

10.7 News Ticker Overlay Screen

screen news_ticker(message):

 frame:

 xalign 0.5

 yalign 0.98

 xsize 1280

 ysize 45

 background "#050510aa"

text "[message]" size 18 color "#00ffcc" xalign 0.5 yalign 0.5

11. Theme Integration Analysis: "Beneath the Surface"

This project does not treat the theme as a superficial label; the vertical architecture is built directly into the game's mechanics, narrative, and aesthetic choices:

Concept Layer	The Surface Facade	The Reality Beneath
Environmental	Holographic skyways, automated trains, towering luxury corporate offices.	Flooded maintenance tunnels, industrial waste canals, scrap-metal slums.
Mechanics	Spoken dialogue (civil, structured, corporate-friendly, protective).	Internal monologue (raw, terrified, exhausted, protective, real).
Character A	Well-to-do middle-class technician, productive unit, secure corporate housing.	Spiritually vacant, emotionally isolated, functioning purely as a cog.
Character B	Spontaneous, lively, vibrant street nomad, free from scheduling corporate bounds.	Unprotected, shivering in the rain, lacking identity, hounded by state forces.
Societal	GDP growth, safety statistics, corporate healthcare and wellness marketing.	Systemic class locking, deletion of outcasts, violent private security raids.

12. Pitch Copy (For README and Submission)

Where the Rainbow Ends is a noir-cyberpunk visual novel set in an alternate, fragmented postwar Japan. In the glittering metropolitan corridor of Tokyo, technology, automation, and soaring corporate profits paint a picture of flawless modern success. But beneath this brilliant neon shell lies an stark landscape of

extreme class inequality, absolute identity tracking, and deep psychological alienation.

When A, a spiritually hollow corporate engineer, crosses paths with B, a lively yet unregistered street-level scavenger, their mutual misconceptions of each other begin to fracture. Utilizing an innovative split-screen dialogue system that displays a character's spoken words side-by-side with their real, hidden internal thoughts, the game transforms the theme "Beneath the Surface" from a simple backdrop into an interactive, psychological narrative mechanic. Unveil the systemic and human cost of a perfect city.

Summary of Changes & Updates

1. **Full English Translation:** Every section has been translated from Chinese to natural, evocative English suited for an interactive fiction/visual novel design document.
2. **Standardized Terminology:** Terms like "Megacorp," "Tokyo Corridor," "unregistered populations," and "split-screen dialogue" have been unified throughout the document.
3. **Ren'Py Code Polish:** All placeholder text, strings, variable names, and comments inside the Ren'Py scripts have been translated into English to ensure complete structural clarity.
4. **Formatting Excellence:** Headers, comparative tables, and ASCII-styled flowcharts have been meticulously polished for maximum readability.

Let us know if you would like to draft some of the specific dialogue scripts for **Act III** or refine the Python functions for the split-screen system!

Where the Rainbow Ends

Beneath the Neon

1. Project Overview

Beneath the Neon 是一个运行在网页端的 cyberpunk visual novel。故事发生在一个架空历史中的分裂日本。东京不再是统一国家的首都，而是由巨型企业、监控系统、消费娱乐和科技产业共同维持的半自治经济区。

玩家扮演一名 Mega Corp 工程师 A。他生活在城市的中产阶级表层：稳定工作、企业住房、自动交通、发达科技、干净的商业区。但在一次前往 Neon Pub 的夜晚，他遇见了底层青年 B。B 没有固定工作，靠零工、电子垃圾、地下市场和临时住所生存。

游戏的核心体验是：玩家最初看到的是一个繁荣、高效、炫目的东京；随着剧情推进，逐渐发现这个城市的光鲜表面之下隐藏着阶级固化、监控控制、精神空洞和被忽略的人。

原始设定中已经明确写到，这个东京“above ground”是霓虹摩天楼、自动列车、全息广告和人工洁净，而“below ground”则是 flooded tunnels、illegal markets、ruined shelters、gang-controlled sectors、homeless communities 和 cybernetic junkyards；这正好可以作为项目的核心视觉与叙事结构。

2. Core Message

表面：

东京是世界电子工程与消费科技的中心。
城市明亮、有序、高效，GDP 上升，生产率提高，科技不断进步。

表面之下：

底层居民缺乏稳定身份和上升渠道。
中产阶级虽然有工作和住房，却在重复劳动、企业监控和精神麻木中逐渐失去自我。

核心主题：

A city can look successful while the people inside it are quietly breaking.

或者更贴合比赛主题：

The project reveals the social and emotional decay hidden beneath the surface of a prosperous cyberpunk city.

你原始文件里写到的核心思想是：这个日本看起来 shiny，经济增长、生产率提高、GDP 提高，但内部已经腐烂；底层受到贫富差距和阶级固化压迫，中产则受到精神空虚、重复生活和社会去人性化影响。这个思想非常适合 **Beneath the Surface**，因为它不是字面上的“地下”，而是社会系统和人物心理层面的隐藏真相。

3. Genre and Format

类型

Cyberpunk Visual Novel / Interactive Narrative Experience

平台

Web-based game

运行在网页上，不需要复杂后端。适合 hackathon demo。

核心玩法

玩家阅读剧情，在关键节点做少量选择。游戏使用 split-screen dialogue system：

左侧

右侧

角色说出口的话 角色真实的心理活动

这个机制来自你原始设定：屏幕左右两侧分别展示 spoken words 和 mental thoughts。它和主题非常契合，因为玩家看到的不只是“表面语言”，还能看到“语言之下的真实情绪”。

4. Worldbuilding

4.1 Alternate History Background

这个世界的日本在二战后没有像现实中一样迅速重建并统一，而是在长期轰炸、封锁、饥荒和内部崩溃后被盟军分割成多个占领区。日本不再作为单一国家存在。

主要地区包括：

地区	特征
Kantō Administrative Zone	以东京为中心，受美国企业利益影响
Northern Reconstruction Republic	北海道与北东北，受苏联影响
Kansai Federation	大阪、京都、神户，工业化但政治不稳定
Western Maritime Authority	广岛、九州及海军区域，由多国委员会控制
Buffer Territories	边境缓冲区和废墟地带

你的原始时间线中，1945 年后的日本因为长期战争创伤和国际势力竞争而被分裂；1953 年统一谈判失败；此后黑市、走私、边境城市和企业势力逐渐扩大。

4.2 Rise of the Megacorps

1950s 后期，分裂日本面对严重经济危机：基础设施破坏、失业、出生率下降、组织犯罪扩大。弱势政府为了维持秩序，把越来越多公共职能交给大型工业企业。

这些企业控制：

- 交通系统；
- 消费电子生产；
- 私人安保；
- 企业住房；
- 食物分配；
- 学校和医院；
- 边境检查；
- 情报网络。

到 1977 年，巨型企业已经超过政府本身。富人住在高层 sterile towers，穷人住在 elevated highways 下、flooded subway tunnels 中和 abandoned wartime ruins 里。你的原始文件直接写到 Tokyo becomes the most unequal city on Earth，这是世界观的核心阶级矛盾。

4.3 The Tokyo Corridor

1981 年，几个大型企业在东京形成半统一经济区，非正式名称为：

The Tokyo Corridor

它是一个高度商业化、霓虹化、监控化的城市。

Surface Tokyo

玩家第一眼看到的东京：

- neon skyscrapers;
- luxury corporate districts;
- automated trains;
- holographic billboards;
- artificial cleanliness;
- endless advertisements;
- synthetic entertainment;
- neural-interface technology;
- autonomous factory robotics。

Beneath Tokyo

后续逐渐揭露的东京：

- flooded tunnels;
- illegal markets;
- ruined wartime shelters;
- gang-controlled sectors;
- homeless communities;
- cybernetic junkyards;
- power outages;
- black-market clinics;
- corporate security replacing law enforcement。

这个上下结构就是项目最重要的视觉逻辑：城市越往上越干净、明亮、有效率；越往下越潮湿、混乱、危险、真实。

5. Main Characters

Character A — The Corporate Engineer

基本设定

A 是 Mega Corp 的中层技术工程师。他属于中产阶级，有稳定工作、企业身份、住房和社会地位。但他每天重复同样的日程，逐渐感到精神麻木和自我消失。

你原始设定中写到 A 是 introvert、technical、observant, 并且会用 intellectualism 掩盖 exhaustion; 他有一定社会经济地位, 但因为每天重复的 schedule 感到 numb 和 mental emptiness。

性格关键词

- introverted;
- technical;
- observant;
- emotionally restrained;
- intellectually defensive;
- socially functional but internally exhausted;
- masking fatigue behind rational language。

表面形象

A 看起来是城市成功系统的一部分：

- 有工作；
- 有 ID；
- 有企业住房；
- 有稳定收入；
- 能进入干净商业区；
- 被城市系统承认为“valid citizen”。

表面之下

A 的问题不是贫困, 而是异化：

- 没有真正的人际关系；
- 把情绪转化成理性分析；
- 对生活没有期待；
- 被重复日程掏空；
- 像机器齿轮一样运转；
- 不知道自己到底想要什么。

角色功能

A 代表：

The emptiness hidden beneath middle-class stability.

Character B — The Drifter

基本设定

B 是底层青年，没有固定工作，靠 odd jobs、捡电子垃圾、地下市场交易和临时机会生存。他外向、能量强、善于社交，但这种“自由”其实是一种没有保护、没有身份、没有稳定未来的生存状态。

你原始文件中写到 B 是 extrovert、energetic、social，但 lower class、no fixed job，只能做 odd jobs。

性格关键词

- extroverted;
- energetic;
- socially adaptive;
- impulsive;
- uses humor defensively;
- often unaware of emotional friction;
- outwardly free, inwardly unstable.

表面形象

A 最初看到的 B:

- 自由;
- 活跃;
- 直接;
- 不被公司日程束缚;
- 好像比 A 更“像活着的人”。

表面之下

B 的真实处境:

- 没有稳定住所;
- 缺乏正式身份;
- 被 security 驱赶;
- 没有上升通道;
- 只能在城市缝隙中生存;
- 用玩笑掩盖恐惧和绝望。

角色功能

B 代表:

The insecurity hidden beneath apparent freedom.

6. Character Relationship

A 和 B 的关系不是简单的“中产拯救底层”，也不是普通 buddy story。更准确地说：

A and B misread each other.

A 以为 B 自由、有生命力、不被系统束缚。

B 以为 A 安全、体面、被城市保护。

但他们后面发现，两个人都被同一个系统困住，只是困住的方式不同。

A 对 B 的误解

A 看到 B 的能量和社交能力，以为 B 拥有自己缺少的自由。

B 对 A 的误解

B 看到 A 的企业身份和稳定生活，以为 A 拥有安全和选择权。

真相

A 有身份，但没有生命感。

B 有行动自由，但没有安全感。

一个被企业系统吸收，一个被企业系统排除。两个人都不真正自由。

7. Plot Outline

Prologue — Surface of Tokyo

故事不从 A 的痛苦开始，而从东京的繁荣表面开始。

玩家看到：

- GDP 增长；
- 自动列车；
- 神经接口广告；
- 合成娱乐；
- 霓虹商业区；
- 企业新闻；
- 干净高效的都市宣传。

但镜头逐渐向下移动，出现第一道裂缝：

- security 清理无证流浪者；
- 城市新闻称其为 urban sanitation；
- 广告仍然播放“Your happiness, measured”；

- A 在车厢中沉默通勤。

这一段的目的是：

先建立 **surface**, 再埋下 **beneath** 的不安。

Act I — Neon Pub

A 因为企业 wellness recommendation, 或者因为自己想证明还能“正常社交”, 前往 Neon Pub。

Neon Pub 是城市表面繁荣的缩影：

- loud synth music;
- holographic advertisements;
- expensive drinks;
- corporate workers pretending to relax;
- gang members and smugglers hidden inside crowd;
- 每个人都在表演自己还活着。

A 进入后发现自己无法融入。他观察、分析、疲惫, 但没有真正参与。

在 pub 外, B 正在寻找被中上层消费者丢弃的电子垃圾: access tags、broken chips、drink cartridges、scrapped neural adapters。两人第一次相遇。

核心剧情功能：

- A 第一次看到 B;
 - B 给 A 留下强烈印象;
 - A 把 B 误读为“自由的人”;
 - 玩家第一次看到城市繁华边缘的底层生存。
-

Act II — Subway / Street Encounter

A 对 Neon Pub 失望, 决定离开。他走向 subway station。

路上, 他开始在心里比较自己和 B:

- 自己有工作但麻木;
- B 没有固定生活但看似自由;
- 自己被日程困住;
- B 好像还能随意行动。

在 subway 或 station 外, 他再次遇到 B。这里可以加入一个更合理的剧情动机：

B 在 Neon Pub 外捡到了 A 掉落的 corporate ID。
对 A 来说, 这张卡代表工作权限、交通权限和社会身份。
对 B 来说, 这张卡像是进入上层世界的门票。

随后 corporate security 开始检查无证人员。A 必须决定是否帮助 B 躲过检查。

核心剧情功能:

- 暴露身份系统;
 - 暴露 corporate security;
 - 让 A 第一次主动介入 B 的生活;
 - 为 A 邀请 B 去 apartment 提供合理动机。
-

Act III — Apartment Conversation

由于暴雨、地铁停运、security 搜查, A 暂时把 B 带回自己的 apartment。

这场戏是人物关系核心。

对 A 来说, apartment 是狭窄、重复、压抑的空间。
对 B 来说, apartment 已经是奢侈: 有门、有床、有电、有热水、有不会漏雨的天花板。

这场对话围绕三个主题:

1. Work

A 的工作稳定但抽空自我。
B 的工作自由但没有保障。

2. Identity

A 有 corporate ID, 却感觉自己不像真实的人。
B 没有正式身份, 因此在城市系统里几乎不存在。

3. Sleep

A 有床但睡不着。
B 到处都能睡, 但从来不安全。

这一场的目标不是让两人立刻成为朋友, 而是让他们开始意识到: 对方并不是自己想象中的样子。

Act IV — One Month Later

两人分别回到自己的生活，一个月没有见面。

这一段可以做成短 montage, 而不是长剧情：

A 的日常

- wake;
- scan;
- work;
- productivity review;
- commute;
- apartment;
- repeat。

B 的日常

- search for parts;
- dodge security;
- sleep in subway;
- trade scraps;
- joke with strangers;
- disappear into lower districts。

同时屏幕上出现新闻 ticker:

- “Tokyo Corridor Productivity Reaches New High.”
- “Public Satisfaction Remains Stable.”
- “Urban Sanitation Campaign Successful.”
- “Unauthorized Population Reduced.”
- “Consumer Confidence Rising.”

这个 montage 的作用是把主题讲清楚：

数据越来越好，人越来越不像人。

Act V — Rainy Riverbank

一个月后，A 在 rainy riverbank 散步。他不是去找 B，而是因为自己的生活已经让他无处可去。

他看到 B 站在桥边。

这里建议不要直接写成过于明确的 suicide scene，尤其是 hackathon 项目。可以写得更含蓄：

- B 站在桥栏外侧；
- 雨很大；
- 河水很黑；

- A 不确定 B 是在开玩笑、发呆，还是准备消失；
- 两人进行最后一次对话。

核心不应该是“救不救 B”，而是：

两个人终于看见对方表面之下的真实状态。

A 不再把 B 当成自由的象征。

B 也不再把 A 当成安全的上层人。

他们发现对方都只是城市系统里的残余个体。

Ending — Ambiguous Resolution

结尾应该保持 ambiguous，但不应该显得没写完。

可以有三个版本：

Ending A — Quiet Survival

B 从桥边下来。两人一起走向第一班早晨列车。

城市没有改变，但他们至少暂时没有消失。

Ending B — Reflection

镜头停在河面。霓虹灯倒映在污染的水里。

玩家不知道 B 是否下来，只听到 A 的心理独白。

Ending C — City Continues

画面切到新闻屏幕：

Tokyo Corridor Economic Confidence Reaches Record High.

然后黑屏。

这个结尾最冷，强调城市机器不会因为个人痛苦而停止。

8. Scene Settings

Scene 0 — Prologue: Surface of Tokyo

时间

08:00 PM

功能

展示东京的繁荣表面。

视觉

- aerial city shot;
- neon skyline;
- holographic koi;
- automated trains;
- glass towers;
- luxury advertisements;
- corporate news montage。

beneath hint

- 被 security 带走的无证者；
 - 过度官方的新闻语言；
 - A 在车厢里的沉默；
 - “happiness measured / wellness monitored” 之类的广告语。
-

Scene A — The Apartment

原始设定

你的文件中 Scene A 是 02:00 AM 的 cramped apartment, 床、桌子和 kitchenette 几乎重叠, 但 dim yellow lights 和 electronics hum 给它一种脆弱的温暖感。这个空间让玩家暂时从东京的 endless motion 中隔离出来。

功能

展示 A 的真实生活状态。

表面

中产企业住房。
安全、私密、有电、有设备。

表面之下

狭窄、重复、孤独、像储存人的机器格子。

Scene B — The Neon Pub

原始设定

Neon Pub 位于 elevated highways 和 holographic billboards 之下，里面有 exhausted workers、gang members、smugglers 和 corporate employees。空间里有烟雾、人工蒸汽、synth music 和 aggressive neon。

功能

展示娱乐消费如何掩盖社会疲劳。

表面

繁华、热闹、自由、社交、享乐。

表面之下

每个人都在逃避。
中产在假装放松，底层在寻找机会，犯罪和商业混在一起。

Scene C — The Rainy Riverbank

原始设定

河流穿过 concrete floodwalls 和 industrial districts，酸雨落在 rusted guardrails 和 cracked pedestrian paths 上。这里比市中心安静，但并不和平，东京的压力仍然存在于每个声音和雨滴里。

功能

最终对话场景。

表面

安静、反思、远离城市中心。

表面之下

污染、绝望、边缘感、无处可去的人。

Scene D — Subway / Taxi Ride

原始设定

Tokyo transit 是一台 never sleeps 的机器:subway platforms 里有 exhausted commuters、intoxicated workers、students、street criminals 和 corporate agents;train announcements、rails、electronic jingles 和 arguments 重叠。尽管混乱,一切仍然继续运转。

功能

展示“秩序”和“失控”同时存在。

表面

交通高效、城市运转正常。

表面之下

人群疲惫、身份检查、监控、底层被驱赶、城市像机器一样吞吐人。

9. Main Gameplay

9.1 Gameplay Overview

Beneath the Neon 是一个以剧情推进为核心的 **Ren'Py visual novel**。玩家主要通过阅读对白、观察角色心理、在关键节点做少量选择来体验故事。

游戏不追求大量交互、开放地图或复杂探索,而是强调:

玩家最初看到东京的繁荣表面,随后逐渐发现隐藏在霓虹、科技、消费和秩序之下的阶级压迫、身份控制和精神空洞。

这和原始设定中的核心玩法一致:游戏本质是 visual novel, 主线剧情固定,但玩家会在部分节点做选择;屏幕左右分别呈现角色说出口的话和内心想法。

9.2 Core Player Experience

玩家体验分为三层:

第一层:观看城市表面

游戏开头先展示 Tokyo Corridor 的繁荣:

- neon skyline;

- automated trains;
- holographic advertisements;
- neural-interface products;
- clean corporate districts;
- economic news about productivity and growth。

这一部分几乎不需要玩家操作，主要是 cinematic opening。目标是让玩家先相信这个城市是成功、先进、漂亮的。

第二层：发现表面裂缝

进入 Neon Pub、Subway、Apartment 后，玩家开始看到城市表面之下的问题：

- security 清理无证者；
- 底层人在商业区边缘寻找电子垃圾；
- 中产工人表面体面但精神麻木；
- 地铁系统高效运转，但人群疲惫、沉默、被监控；
- corporate language 把社会问题包装成“sanitation”“wellness”“productivity”。

BasisHacks 的主题强调项目应该揭示 first glance 之外隐藏的东西，也可以探索社会、情绪和系统层面的 deeper truth；这个玩法结构正好把主题嵌入体验本身。

第三层：理解人物真实状态

A 和 B 都有一个“表面”和“表面之下”。

A 表面上是稳定、体面、有身份的 Mega Corp 工程师；实际上他被重复生活和企业系统掏空。
B 表面上自由、外向、有能量；实际上他没有固定工作、没有稳定住所，也没有真正的安全感。
这个对照来自原始人物设定：A 是 technical、introverted、masking exhaustion 的中产工程师；
B 是 energetic、social、lower-class、无固定工作的底层流动者。

9.3 Split-Screen Dialogue System

游戏最核心的机制是 **split-screen dialogue**。

屏幕左侧显示角色说出口的话。

屏幕右侧显示角色真实的心理活动。

例子：

Spoken Dialogue

Internal Thought

“Just one drink.”

He did not want a drink. He wanted proof that he could still pass as alive.

“Must be nice, having a room.”

Don’t sound jealous. Make it a joke.

“I’m fine.”

The sentence had been used too often. It no longer meant anything.

这个机制直接服务主题：

What people say is the surface.

What they hide is beneath the surface.

玩家不是单纯阅读对白，而是在比较“外在表达”和“内在真实”。这比普通 visual novel 更能体现主题。

9.4 Player Choices

玩家选择数量要少，但每个选择都要有意义。建议每个主要场景只设置 **1-2** 个选择。

选择不应该大幅改变主线，而应该改变：

- A 如何理解 B；
- B 是否愿意信任 A；
- 对话的语气；
- 角色心理描写；
- 结尾的暧昧程度。

不建议做大量 branching，因为这个项目更适合一个 polished narrative demo，而不是大型多结局游戏。

9.5 Hidden Variables

游戏可以使用几个隐藏变量控制文本变化：

Variable	Function
<code>trust</code>	A 和 B 是否愿意说真话
<code>projection</code>	两人是否仍然误解对方
<code>noise</code>	城市压力、疲劳、监控和精神负荷
<code>masking</code>	A 是否继续用理性语言掩盖情绪

这些变量不需要显示给玩家。它们只影响：

- 某些 dialogue variant；
- internal thought 的措辞；
- ending 的 tone；
- 新闻 ticker 和 UI glitch 的强度。

9.6 Main Gameplay Flow

推荐 demo 流程如下：

Prologue — Surface of Tokyo

↓

Scene 1 — Neon Pub

↓

Scene 2 — Subway Checkpoint

↓

Scene 3 — Apartment Conversation

↓

Scene 4 — One-Month Montage

↓

Scene 5 — Rainy Riverbank

↓

Ambiguous Ending

Prologue — Surface of Tokyo

几乎无交互。

展示东京的繁荣表面:新闻、广告、自动交通、科技消费、经济增长。

Scene 1 — Neon Pub

玩家第一次控制 A 的回应方式。

A 尝试进入“正常社交”，但发现自己无法融入。B 在 pub 外寻找电子垃圾。

Scene 2 — Subway Checkpoint

第一个关键选择。

B 捡到了 A 的 corporate ID。Security 正在检查无证人员。A 要决定是否帮助 B。

Scene 3 — Apartment Conversation

核心人物对话。

A 和 B 开始发现对方并不像自己想象的那样。

Scene 4 — One-Month Montage

快速展示两人回到各自生活。

A 重复工作, B 继续漂泊。城市新闻继续报告经济增长和社会稳定。

Scene 5 — Rainy Riverbank

最终对话。

A 看到 B 站在桥边。两人第一次真正看见对方的真实状态。

Ending

结尾保持 ambiguous。

城市不会被改变, 但玩家会理解城市繁荣表面之下的人性损耗。

10. Technical Structure

10.1 Engine

项目使用 **Ren'Py** 开发。

Ren'Py 适合这个项目的原因：

- 专门用于 visual novel；
- 自带 dialogue、choice、scene transition、save/load；
- 支持 Python-style variables；
- 适合快速完成 polished narrative demo；
- 可以导出 Windows / macOS / Linux 桌面版本；
- 比从零写游戏框架更高效。

因为现在不做网页版，所以技术重点不再是浏览器部署，而是：

做出一个稳定、可下载、可演示的桌面端 Ren'Py visual novel。

10.2 Deliverables

最终提交建议包括：

1. Ren'Py game build
2. GitHub / Gitee repository
3. README.md
4. 1–3 minute demo video
5. Short project description / pitch

BasisHacks 要求项目有公开 GitHub 或 Gitee、README、playable or demo version、1–3 分钟 demo video，并且需要 meaningful theme integration。

10.3 Project Folder Structure

推荐结构：

BeneathTheNeon/

|

| — game/

| | — script.rpy

- | |— characters.rpy
- | |— screens.rpy
- | |— variables.rpy
- | |— dialogue_variants.rpy
- | |— audio.rpy
- | |— gui.rpy
- | |
- | |— images/
 - | | |— backgrounds/
 - | | | |— bg_tokyo_surface.png
 - | | | |— bg_neon_pub.png
 - | | | |— bg_subway.png
 - | | | |— bg_apartment.png
 - | | | |— bg_riverbank.png
 - | | |
 - | | |— characters/
 - | | | |— a_neutral.png
 - | | | |— a_tired.png
 - | | | |— b_smirk.png
 - | | | |— b_quiet.png
 - | | |
 - | | |— ui/
 - | | | |— textbox_left.png
 - | | | |— textbox_right.png
 - | | | |— ticker_bar.png
- | |

```
| |— audio/
| | |— rain_loop.ogg
| | |— neon_pub.ogg
| | |— subway_hum.ogg
| | |— riverbank_rain.ogg
| | |— corporate_jingle.ogg
| |
| |— fonts/
| | |— ui_font.ttf
|
|— README.md
|— credits.md
|— demo_video.mp4
```

10.4 Script Structure

主线剧情放在 `script.rpy` 中, 用 Ren'Py label 管理。

label start:

```
    jump prologue_surface
```

label prologue_surface:

```
    # Surface-level opening of Tokyo

    jump neon_pub
```

label neon_pub:

```
    # A enters Neon Pub and first notices B

    jump subway_checkpoint
```

```
label subway_checkpoint:
```

```
    # B has A's ID; security appears
```

```
    jump apartment_conversation
```

```
label apartment_conversation:
```

```
    # A and B talk in A's apartment
```

```
    jump one_month_montage
```

```
label one_month_montage:
```

```
    # Repetition and separation
```

```
    jump riverbank
```

```
label riverbank:
```

```
    # Final conversation
```

```
    jump ending
```

这样结构清楚，方便 hackathon 中快速完成。

10.5 Character Definitions

角色定义放在 `characters.rpy`:

```
define n = Character(None)
```

```
define a = Character("A")
```

```
define b = Character("B")
```

```
define news = Character("News")
```

```
define system = Character("System")
```

如果使用 split-screen, 不一定用 Ren'Py 默认 dialogue box。可以保留角色定义, 但主要对白通过自定义 screen 显示。

10.6 Variables

隐藏变量放在 `variables.rpy`:

```
default trust = 0
```

```
default projection = 0
```

```
default noise = 0
```

```
default masking = 0
```

变量作用:

```
$ trust += 1
```

```
$ projection -= 1
```

```
$ noise += 1
```

```
$ masking += 1
```

这些变量用于控制后续文本:

```
if trust >= 2:
```

```
    jump apartment_high_trust
```

```
else:
```

```
    jump apartment_low_trust
```

10.7 Split-Screen Dialogue Implementation

建议创建一个自定义 screen, 例如 `dual_dialogue`。

功能:

- 左侧显示 spoken dialogue;
- 右侧显示 internal thought;
- 底部可以显示 speaker;
- 背景仍然是当前 scene;

- 点击继续下一句。

概念结构：

screen dual_dialogue(speaker, spoken, thought):

frame:

xalign 0.05

yalign 0.75

xsize 600

ysize 220

text "[speaker] says:" size 24

text "[spoken]" size 30

frame:

xalign 0.95

yalign 0.75

xsize 600

ysize 220

text "[speaker] thinks:" size 24

text "[thought]" size 26 italic True

然后可以用 Python 函数包装：

init python:

```
def dual_line(speaker, spoken, thought):
```

```
    renpy.call_screen("dual_dialogue", speaker=speaker, spoken=spoken, thought=thought)
```

实际写剧情时：

```
$ dual_line("A", "Just one drink.", "He did not want a drink. He wanted proof that he could  
still pass as alive.")
```

这个系统就是项目的 technical highlight。

10.8 Choice System

选择使用 Ren'Py `menu`:

`menu`:

"Help B pass the checkpoint.":

`$ trust += 1`

`$ projection -= 1`

`jump help_b`

"Ask for the ID first.":

`$ masking += 1`

`jump demand_id`

"Pretend not to know him.":

`$ trust -= 1`

`$ noise += 1`

`jump ignore_b`

主线最后仍然汇合:

`label after_checkpoint:`

`jump apartment_conversation`

这样不会让项目复杂度失控。

10.9 Dialogue Variant System

对白变体放在 `dialogue_variants.rpy`。

可以用 `list` 存储多种版本:

`default subway_b_jokes = [`

"You tower people drop expensive things like they're cigarette ash.",

"Relax. I only borrowed your entire legal identity.",

"Funny. This card opens more doors than your face does."

]

使用时随机调用：

```
$ line = renpy.random.choice(subway_b_jokes)
```

```
b "[line]"
```

如果是 split-screen：

```
$ spoken = renpy.random.choice(subway_b_jokes)
```

```
$ thought = "Keep smiling. If he gets angry, run."
```

```
$ dual_line("B", spoken, thought)
```

这样可以实现 replay variation, 但不会引入实时 AI 的不稳定性。

10.10 News Ticker System

新闻 ticker 是一个低成本但高效果的世界观工具。

它可以出现在屏幕底部：

```
PRODUCTIVITY UP 7.2% | PUBLIC SATISFACTION STABLE | UNAUTHORIZED  
POPULATION REDUCED
```

技术上可以做成一个 custom screen：

```
screen news_ticker(message):
```

```
    frame:
```

```
        xalign 0.5
```

```
        yalign 0.98
```

```
        xsize 1280
```

```
        ysize 40
```

```
        text "[message]" size 20
```


不同场景切换不同 ticker:

```
show screen news_ticker("PRODUCTIVITY RISES FOR SEVENTH CONSECUTIVE QUARTER")
```

这个机制可以持续提醒玩家:城市官方叙事和人物真实体验之间存在巨大差距。

10.11 Visual and Audio Assets

视觉上建议用强对比:

Surface	Beneath
clean neon skyline	flooded tunnels
glass towers	rusted walls
bright ads	broken screens
automated trains	crowded subway platforms
luxury pub lights	garbage electronics
corporate UI	handwritten signs / black market symbols

音频上建议使用:

- rain loop;
- low electrical hum;
- corporate announcement;
- synth music in Neon Pub;
- subway rail noise;
- distant sirens;

- riverbank rain and traffic。

原始场景设定中, Apartment、Neon Pub、Riverbank、Subway 都已经明确声音和视觉氛围: 雨声、电子嗡鸣、synth music、地铁广播、警笛、交通声等, 可以直接转化为 Ren'Py 的 background + audio layers。

10.12 AI Use in Technical Structure

不建议在游戏运行时调用 AI API。

原因:

1. 项目不需要实时生成;
2. API 可能不稳定;
3. 评审重点应是你的设计和实现;
4. AI 使用应低于 30%;
5. Ren'Py 本身更适合预写文本和受控变体。

推荐方式:

AI used during development:

- brainstorm dialogue variants
- generate optional internal thought drafts
- polish atmosphere descriptions

Human-controlled:

- main plot
- worldbuilding
- character arcs
- key dialogue
- ending
- implementation

在 README 中可以这样写:

AI assistance was used only for limited drafting and variation generation. The plot structure, character design, theme integration, implementation, and final text selection were created and curated by the developer.

10.13 Build Plan

最终构建流程：

- 1. Write core script in script.rpy
- 2. Add split-screen dialogue screen
- 3. Add key choices and variables
- 4. Add backgrounds and audio
- 5. Add news ticker overlay
- 6. Add dialogue variants
- 7. Test full playthrough
- 8. Export desktop build
- 9. Upload repository to GitHub/Gitee
- 10. Record 1–3 minute demo video

优先级：

Priority	Feature
Must Have	Main story playable from start to ending
Must Have	Split-screen spoken/thought dialogue
Must Have	At least 3 major scenes
Must Have	1–2 meaningful choices

Should Have News ticker

Should Have Dialogue variants

Nice to Have UI glitch when **noise** is high

Nice to Have Multiple ambiguous ending tones

10.14 Technical Summary

最终技术定位可以写成：

The project is built in Ren'Py as a desktop visual novel. Its main technical feature is a custom split-screen dialogue interface that displays both spoken dialogue and hidden internal thought, turning the theme “Beneath the Surface” into an interactive reading mechanic. The game uses Ren'Py variables to track trust, projection, noise, and masking, which influence dialogue variations and ending tone. Additional systems include a propaganda-style news ticker, prewritten dialogue variants, scene-based audio, and cinematic background transitions.

中文版本：

本项目使用 Ren'Py 开发为桌面端视觉小说。核心技术机制是自定义分屏对白系统，同时展示角色说出口的话与隐藏心理，使 “Beneath the Surface” 不只是故事主题，而是玩家实际体验到的叙事机制。游戏通过 Ren'Py 变量记录 trust、projection、noise 和 masking，影响对白变体和结尾语气；同时加入新闻 ticker、场景音效、背景切换和预写文本变体来增强世界观与重玩体验。

11. Theme Integration

这个项目和 **Beneath the Surface** 的连接不是后加的，而是核心结构：

Surface

- neon skyline;
- high-tech economy;
- corporate order;
- efficient transit;
- consumer entertainment;
- productivity growth。

Beneath

- hidden poverty;
- corporate surveillance;
- unregistered people;
- social alienation;
- emotional exhaustion;
- underground economies;
- class immobility。

官方主题强调 senior projects 可以探索 emotional、technical、philosophical、societal 层面的隐藏内容，也鼓励 social simulation exposing hidden corruption in a city 这样的方向；你的项目正好属于 cyberpunk social narrative。

12. Final Project Pitch

可以直接放 README 或 demo video 开头：

Beneath the Neon is a web-based cyberpunk visual novel set in an alternate fragmented Japan, where the Tokyo Corridor appears to be a prosperous center of technology, entertainment, and economic growth. Through the meeting between a numb middle-class corporate engineer and an energetic but unstable lower-class drifter, the game reveals the inequality, surveillance, and emotional exhaustion hidden beneath the city's neon surface. The split-screen dialogue system shows both what characters say and what they truly think, turning the theme “Beneath the Surface” into the game's central mechanic.

中文版本：

《**Beneath the Neon**》是一个网页端赛博朋克视觉小说。故事发生在架空历史中的分裂日本，东京走廊表面上是繁荣、高效、科技发达的未来都市，但在霓虹灯和企业广告之下，隐藏着贫富差距、身份控制、底层生存困境和中产精神空洞。玩家通过一名企业工程师 A 与底层流动者 B 的相遇，逐渐揭开城市光鲜表面下被忽视的社会与心理真相。游戏的分屏对白系统同时展示角色说出口的话和真实心理，使 “Beneath the Surface” 成为核心玩法，而不只是主题标签。

13. Plot

14. Revised Plot

14.1 Prologue — Surface of Tokyo

Black screen.

A low electronic hum.

Then, slowly, the city wakes into color.

At first, there is only light.

Neon crawls across the glass skin of Tokyo like a second bloodstream. Tower after tower rises into the wet night, each one cleaner, brighter, and taller than the last. Blue advertisements dissolve into pink. Pink becomes gold. Gold becomes the logo of another company promising comfort, health, memory, desire, sleep.

Above the streets, automated trains cut through the skyline without sound. Their windows reflect holographic koi swimming between office towers. Below them, traffic moves in perfect lanes, guided by corporate navigation systems that correct every delay before anyone can feel it.

A woman on a billboard smiles with impossible calm.

ADVERTISEMENT:

Your happiness, measured.

Your wellness, monitored.

Your future, optimized.

The smile repeats across a thousand screens.

On the news towers, the same headlines rotate every thirty seconds.

NEWS:

Tokyo Corridor productivity rises for the seventh consecutive quarter.

NEWS:

Consumer confidence reaches a five-year high.

NEWS:

Corporate housing satisfaction remains stable.

NEWS:

Public mobility initiative improves lower-sector transit flow.

The headlines are clean.

The fonts are clean.

Even the rain seems clean as it falls through the neon.

From a distance, Tokyo looks like proof that history can be repaired by enough light.

Inside Train Line 7, no one speaks.

The train slides above the commercial district, passing office towers, capsule hotels, entertainment malls, private clinics, and vertical gardens sealed behind climate-controlled glass. Every passenger faces forward. Every wristband blinks softly. Every eye avoids every other eye.

Morikawa Reiji sits near the window.

His company badge rests against his coat, still warm from the scanner at the platform gate.

SYSTEM:

Identity confirmed.

Employment status: active.

Transit privilege: approved.

Housing tier: maintained.

Wellness risk: moderate.

Reiji does not look at the message for long.

Outside, another advertisement expands across the side of a building.

ADVERTISEMENT:

Sleep better.

Work clearer.

Feel human again.

Reiji watches the words slide across the rain.

REIJI — spoken:

“Almost home.”

REIJI — thought:

Home was the word the system used because “assigned residential unit” tested poorly in employee satisfaction surveys.

The train enters a tunnel of reflected light.

For a few seconds, the window becomes a mirror.

Reiji sees his own face layered over the city: tired eyes, pressed collar, company haircut, the expression of someone who has learned to look functional before learning to feel anything.

His wrist display vibrates.

Not a message from a person.

A work archive.

NAKAMURA NEURAL SYSTEMS — DEPLOYMENT REPORT:

Civic Access Optimization Patch 7.3 submitted.

Engineer of record: Morikawa Reiji.

Transit-identity integration: updated.

Corporate housing gate recognition: updated.

Public wellness scanner sync: updated.

Unauthorized congestion prediction: improved by 18.4%.

Reiji's thumb hovers over the report.

The train lights flicker once.

The report continues.

DEPLOYMENT SUMMARY:

Objective: improve urban mobility.

Objective: reduce unauthorized bottlenecks.

Objective: protect registered citizens.

There is a button at the bottom.

CONFIRM FINAL REVIEW.

Reiji presses it.

The screen turns green.

SYSTEM:

Thank you for your contribution.

His reflection remains in the window after the report disappears.

For a moment, the green confirmation mark sits over his left eye.

Then the train leaves the tunnel.

Below, on a service platform between two transit lines, three corporate security officers surround a man without shoes. The man holds a plastic bag against his chest. Something metallic spills from it onto the concrete: broken circuits, old access tags, cracked lenses, a child's toy with one glowing eye.

A portable scanner opens in one officer's hand.

Green light moves across the man's face.

Then yellow.

Then red.

The nearest gate shuts before the man reaches it.

Reiji's fingers tighten around his bag.

One officer speaks into his shoulder mic.

Another points toward the lower stairwell.

The man shakes his head.

The train continues moving before Reiji can see what happens next.

Reiji looks away.

The news tower outside updates.

NEWS:

Urban mobility improved in lower transit sectors.

No one in the train reacts.

A child across the aisle watches a cartoon through retinal projection. Her pupils flicker with artificial stars. Her mother sits beside her, asleep with her mouth slightly open, still wearing an office headset. Every few seconds, the headset whispers into her ear.

HEADSET:

Rest cycle detected.

Micro-recovery in progress.

Thank you for your contribution.

The train arrives at Shinjuku Corporate Exchange.

The doors open.

A wall of sound enters the carriage: station chimes, shoe steps, synthetic announcements, distant music, vending machine jingles, security drones, rainwater dripping from coats onto polished floor.

ANNOUNCEMENT:

Welcome to Shinjuku Corporate Exchange.

Please keep your badge visible.

Unregistered persons are not permitted beyond the yellow zone.

Reiji steps out with the crowd.

No one pushes.

No one slows.

Everyone moves as if the station has already decided where their bodies should go.

At the far end of the platform, two security drones hover above the yellow zone. Their lenses rotate slowly. A woman carrying a paper bag stops before the checkpoint, searches her pockets, and searches again.

The people behind her change lanes without looking at her face.

Reiji keeps walking.

His badge flashes green at the exit gate.

The gate opens before he touches it.

Behind him, the woman is still searching.

The gate closes.

Above the platform, another billboard blooms to life.

A group of young office workers laugh around a glowing table in a bar. Their faces are flushed, beautiful, effortless.

ADVERTISEMENT:

NEON PUB.

After work, become yourself again.

Reiji stops walking for half a second.

The crowd bends around him without noticing.

His wrist display lights up again.

SYSTEM:

Wellness variance below recommended threshold.

Controlled social exposure required.

Suggested venue: Neon Pub.

Distance: 0.8 km.

Estimated improvement in emotional variance: 12%.

Reiji stares at the word "required."

The message expands.

SYSTEM:

Failure to complete recommended exposure may affect housing wellness score.

The billboard workers laugh again.

Their glasses shine.

Their mouths open at the same angle.

Reiji almost laughs.

It comes out as a breath.

REIJI — spoken:

“Sure.”

REIJI — thought:

He did not want a drink. He wanted the system to stop noticing that he did not want anything.

He follows the station signs upward.

The escalator carries him toward the commercial level. The walls become brighter with every floor. Concrete disappears behind chrome. Security gates disappear behind decorative glass. The air begins to smell less like rain and more like citrus disinfectant.

At the top, Tokyo opens again.

The commercial district spreads beneath the elevated highway: food stalls with artificial steam, glass storefronts, capsule hotels, memory kiosks, vending machines selling sleep patches and hangover filters. Screens hang from every wall. Every screen promises a different cure for the same exhaustion.

A small drone passes over Reiji's shoulder.

DRONE:

Public comfort scan in progress.

Thank you for remaining visible.

Reiji does not look up.

Neon Pub sits under the highway, surrounded by holographic banners and steam from street vents. Corporate workers line up outside, laughing too loudly. A pair of smugglers argue near a vending machine. A woman in a silver jacket sells illegal memory patches from inside an umbrella.

Security drones pass overhead.

They ignore the silver jacket.

They ignore the smugglers.

They continue toward the lower stairwell.

Music pulses from the pub entrance.

For a moment, the whole street looks alive.

Then Reiji notices the alley behind it.

There are people there, half-hidden behind stacked delivery crates, picking through discarded electronics from the pub. Broken drink cartridges. Cracked neural adapters. Burnt-out access chips. Anything with a trace of metal, memory, or resale value.

One of them looks up.

A young man.

Thin jacket. Wet hair. Bright eyes. A grin too quick to be trusted.

Ren.

Their eyes meet for less than a second.

Ren raises two fingers in a casual salute, as if they are old friends, as if being seen is not dangerous.

Reiji looks away first.

The pub doors open.

Warm light spills across the street.

Behind him, the billboard woman smiles again.

ADVERTISEMENT:

Your happiness, measured.

The rain keeps falling.

The city keeps shining.

Reiji steps toward the entrance.

Behind him, in the alley, someone laughs softly.

Then the music swallows it.

END OF PROLOGUE

14.2 Act I — Neon Pub

Scene 1 — Entrance

Background: Neon Pub exterior.

Rain falls between the elevated highway and the entrance of Neon Pub.

The pub is built under layers of road, rail, pipe, and advertisement. Above it, automated traffic moves in silent lanes. Below it, water gathers in the cracks of the pavement, reflecting pink, blue, and gold until the ground looks more expensive than it is.

The sign above the entrance flickers.

BILLBOARD:

NEON PUB

After work, become yourself again.

Reiji stands across the street.

A line of corporate workers waits at the door. Their coats are dark, their shoes polished, their badges visible. Some laugh too loudly. Some check their wrist displays. Some have already loosened their collars in the exact same way.

Reiji feels his own badge against his chest.

Warm. Authorized. Valid.

REIJI — spoken:

“Just one drink.”

REIJI — thought:

He did not want a drink. He wanted proof that he could still enter a place designed for living people and not be mistaken for equipment.

He crosses the street.

A scanning gate unfolds from the pub entrance. A blue line passes over his face, his hands, his badge.

SYSTEM POPUP:

Identity confirmed.

Corporate employee discount applied.

Wellness venue participation recorded.

The gate opens.

The bouncer does not look at him.

Reiji steps inside.

Scene 2 — Inside the Pub

Background: Neon Pub interior.

The first thing Reiji notices is the sound.

Not music exactly.

A rhythm engineered to keep the body alert without allowing thought to settle. Synthetic bass shakes the floor. Glasses click. Steam vents hiss. Laughter rises too sharply, then disappears under the next wave of sound.

The room is crowded, but not intimate.

Corporate workers fill the center tables, still wearing office clothes, sleeves rolled up with deliberate looseness. A group of private security contractors occupies the back wall. Two men with illegal ocular implants speak quietly near the restroom. A woman with silver nails sells memory patches from a booth disguised as a karaoke terminal.

Everyone looks like they are escaping something.

Everyone also looks like they paid to do it.

Reiji walks to the bar.

Behind the counter, transparent bottles glow from within. Their labels promise relaxation, clarity, courage, sleep, desire, social ease.

The bartender smiles automatically.

BARTENDER — spoken:

“First time tonight?”

BARTENDER — thought:

Badge tier B. Corporate discount. Low tip probability.

REIJI — spoken:

“Is it that obvious?”

REIJI — thought:

Yes. It is always obvious when someone is trying to look natural.

The bartender gestures toward the menu.

DRINK MENU:

SOCIAL LIFT

CALM STATIC

SLEEP WITHOUT DREAMS

NEON CLASSIC

WATER

Choice — What does Reiji order?

Option 1 — “Neon Classic.”

Variable suggestion:

`masking += 1`

REIJI — spoken:

“Neon Classic.”

REIJI — thought:

Order the normal thing. Perform the normal shape.

The bartender places a glowing glass in front of him.

It tastes like citrus, metal, and someone else’s idea of youth.

Option 2 — “Calm Static.”

Variable suggestion:

`noise -= 1`

`masking += 1`

REIJI — spoken:

“Calm Static.”

REIJI — thought:

If calm could be purchased, someone would have patented it by now.

The drink arrives pale blue.

For three seconds after he swallows, the room feels farther away.

Then the bass returns.

Option 3 — “Water.”

Variable suggestion:

`projection -= 1`

The bartender pauses.

Only for half a second.

BARTENDER — spoken:

“Water?”

BARTENDER — thought:

Then why are you here?

REIJI — spoken:

“Water.”

REIJI — thought:

Because the system did not specify alcohol.

The bartender gives him a glass without the automatic smile.

Scene 3 — Performed Relaxation

Reiji takes his drink to a narrow standing table near the wall.

From here, he can see almost everything.

A supervisor from Nakamura Neural Systems laughs with two junior analysts. Reiji recognizes one of them from the transit-identity integration floor. At work, she speaks in clean status updates. Here, she tilts her head back and laughs as if someone has given her permission.

A man in a suit raises his glass.

CORPORATE WORKER — spoken:

“To surviving another week.”

CORPORATE WORKER — thought:

Please let Monday be far away.

The others cheer.

Their wrist displays flash.

SYSTEM POPUP:

Group leisure interaction detected.

Social variance improved.

One woman sees the notification and laughs harder.

The laughter spreads because it is easier than stopping.

Reiji looks down at his own wrist display.

SYSTEM POPUP:

Wellness exposure in progress.
Estimated compliance completion: 64%.

Reiji closes the message.

The wall screen above the bar switches to corporate news.

NEWS SCREEN:

Public mobility improved in lower transit sectors.
Commercial confidence remains strong.
Evening entertainment participation exceeds projection.

The headline scrolls under the music.

No one reads it.

A security contractor at the back table says something Reiji cannot hear. His friends laugh.
One of them makes a gesture like shoving someone through a gate.

Reiji looks toward the door.

Near the entrance, a drunk office worker drops a cigarette cartridge. It rolls under a table. A cleaner drone appears immediately, collects it, and disappears into a wall slot.

Nothing stays on the floor long enough to become evidence.

Reiji finishes half of his drink.

He does not feel better.

He only feels recorded.

REIJI — spoken:

"I need air."

REIJI — thought:

The room was full of people proving they were alive. That made it harder to breathe.

He leaves the glass on the table and walks toward the exit.

As he passes through the door, the scanner chimes again.

SYSTEM POPUP:

Wellness venue participation recorded.
Compliance status: partial.

Outside, the rain feels colder than before.

It also feels honest.

Scene 4 — Alley Behind Neon Pub

Background: Alley behind Neon Pub.

The music dulls as the door shuts behind him.

The alley smells of rain, hot plastic, cigarette filters, and burnt circuitry. Delivery crates are stacked against the wall. Discarded electronics spill from black corporate waste bags: broken drink cartridges, cracked neural adapters, old access tags, half-melted wrist displays.

Three people crouch near the trash, sorting quickly.

One keeps copper.

One keeps battery cells.

One keeps anything with memory.

The third one looks up.

Ren.

Thin jacket. Wet hair. Bright eyes. A grin too quick to be trusted.

He holds a cracked holographic koi projector in one hand. Its tail flickers weakly, looping in broken blue light.

REN — spoken:

“You done becoming yourself?”

REN — thought:

Nice coat. Clean shoes. Corporate badge. Don’t stare at the badge.

Reiji stops.

REIJI — spoken:

“You were outside earlier.”

REIJI — thought:

As if that is an accusation. As if standing in rain requires explanation.

Ren turns the broken koi projector over in his hand.

REN — spoken:

“I’m outside a lot.”

REN — thought:

Keep it light. Tower people get nervous when you sound hungry.

The projector sparks.

Ren taps it twice.

The koi swims for half a second, then dies again.

REIJI — spoken:

“That’s damaged.”

REIJI — thought:

Neural display filament. Cheap model. Easy failure.

REN — spoken:

“Everything good is damaged after rich people finish with it.”

REN — thought:

Maybe three hundred yen if I fix the loop. Maybe food if the market auntie is kind.

Reiji looks at the pile of discarded devices.

Some of them are Nakamura models.

He recognizes the interface ports.

He helped test an earlier version.

Ren notices his eyes.

REN — spoken:

“You know this stuff?”

REN — thought:

Engineer. Maybe useful. Maybe dangerous.

REIJI — spoken:

“A little.”

REIJI — thought:

Enough to know who made it. Enough to know who stopped caring after it was sold.

Ren grins.

REN — spoken:

“A little, he says. That means a lot.”

He tosses the broken koi projector up once and catches it.

REN — spoken:

“Machines are more honest when they break. At least then you can see what they were hiding.”

REN — thought:

Too much. Joke again.

Ren points toward Reiji's wrist display.

REN — spoken:

"Yours broken yet?"

Reiji almost answers seriously.

Then a blue light cuts across the alley.

The three scavengers freeze.

A security drone descends from above the elevated highway.

Its lens rotates.

DRONE AUDIO:

Waste-handling zone violation detected.

Please remain still for civic assistance.

One scavenger runs immediately.

The drone turns after him.

Ren does not run.

Not yet.

His hand closes around the broken projector.

REN — spoken:

"Well, that's rude."

REN — thought:

West exit blocked. Pub door locked. Fence too high. Don't run until it chooses someone.

The drone scans the alley.

Blue light passes over Reiji.

Green.

It passes over Ren.

Yellow.

Then yellow again.

DRONE AUDIO:

Identity unclear.

Please present valid registration.

Ren lifts both hands, still smiling.

REN — spoken:

“Left it in my other jacket.”

REN — thought:

If it calls security, drop the bag. If it lowers, kick the lens. If the tower man moves, use him as cover.

Reiji does not move.

The drone’s lens narrows.

DRONE AUDIO:

Please remain still for verification.

Ren glances at Reiji.

Only for a second.

Not asking.

Measuring.

Reiji looks at Ren’s shoes first.

Wet. Split at the sole. Ready to run.

Then Ren’s hand.

Loose. Prepared.

Then the drone.

The same scanner logic as the system he reviewed that afternoon.

REIJI — spoken:

“He’s with the pub.”

The drone pauses.

Ren’s eyes move to Reiji.

REN — thought:

Interesting.

DRONE AUDIO:

Clarify statement.

Reiji steps closer to the waste bags. Rain runs down the back of his neck.

REIJI — spoken:

“Temporary disposal contractor. Manual sorting. The pub’s scanner should have logged him.”

REIJI — thought:

That is barely a lie. That is what the city calls people when it wants them useful.

The drone turns toward the pub entrance.

A line of data flickers across its lens.

For a second, Reiji can see his own badge reflected in the drone’s glass eye.

DRONE AUDIO:

Record incomplete.

Manual review deferred.

Clear waste zone within six minutes.

The drone rises and moves toward the lower stairwell.

Ren lowers his hands.

The other scavengers do not return.

Rain fills the silence.

REN — spoken:

“Temporary disposal contractor?”

REN — thought:

He lied fast. Not cleanly. But fast.

REIJI — spoken:

“It worked.”

REIJI — thought:

Why did I say anything?

Ren steps closer, still holding the broken koi.

REN — spoken:

“You always talk to drones like coworkers?”

REIJI — spoken:

“Only the polite ones.”

Ren laughs.

It is short, sharp, and real enough to surprise Reiji.

For the first time that night, something in the city does not sound processed.

Ren studies him.

REN — spoken:

“You got a name, tower man?”

REIJI — thought:

Do not answer. There is no reason to answer.

REIJI — spoken:

“Reiji.”

Ren repeats it once, as if testing whether it can be useful.

REN — spoken:

“Reiji.”

Then he taps his own chest.

REN — spoken:

“Ren.”

REN — thought:

Not the full name. Never the full name.

Another pulse of music leaks from the pub door.

Behind Ren, the broken projector flickers again. The holographic koi swims through the rain with half a body.

Ren watches it, pleased despite himself.

REN — spoken:

“See? Still alive.”

REN — thought:

Almost fixed. Almost worth something.

Reiji watches him.

Wet jacket. No visible badge. No fixed route. No system popup telling him where to go next.

Ren looks cold, hungry, cornered.

But he also looks impossible to schedule.

For one dangerous second, Reiji envies him.

REIJI — thought:

Maybe freedom looked like having nowhere to return to.

Ren tilts his head.

REN — spoken:

“You look sad for someone with indoor plumbing.”

REIJI — spoken:

“I’m not sad.”

REIJI — thought:

The sentence had been used too often. It no longer meant anything.

Ren smiles like he knows that.

A station announcement echoes from the street beyond the alley.

STATION ANNOUNCEMENT:

Last eastbound express arriving in eight minutes.

Please keep corporate identification visible.

Reiji touches his coat automatically.

The badge is still there.

Or he thinks it is.

His fingers brush the edge of the plastic, then the wet strap of his bag. The clip feels loose.

He does not check.

REIJI — spoken:

“I have to go.”

REN — spoken:

“Sure. Approved routes and all that.”

REN — thought:

Go on, then. People with doors always leave first.

Reiji turns toward the street.

Behind him, Ren crouches again beside the discarded electronics.

The drone is gone.

The music returns.

The rain keeps falling.

Reiji walks toward the subway entrance.

He does not look back a second time.

Behind him, in the alley, something small drops into a puddle.

Plastic.

A soft corporate chime.

Ren looks down.

Blue light reflects from the surface of the water.

He reaches into the puddle and lifts Reiji's badge between two fingers.

For the first time, his grin disappears.

REN — thought:

A door for him.

The badge warms in his hand.

A red notification blinks once.

REN — thought:

A beacon for me.

At the end of the street, Reiji disappears into the station light.

Ren closes his fingers around the badge.

BILLBOARD:

After work, become yourself again.

The broken koi flickers once more in the rain.

Then cuts out.

End of Act I.

14.3 Act II — Subway / Checkpoint

Scene 1 — Street Outside Neon Pub

Background: Street outside Neon Pub. Rain.

The music from Neon Pub fades behind Reiji.

The street is colder now. Rain strikes the elevated highway above him. Steam rises from the gutters. Corporate ads glow in the puddles like the city is trying to sell itself even to the ground.

Reiji walks toward the subway entrance.

Clean white light.

Badge gates.

Approved routes.

He reaches for his corporate ID.

His fingers touch empty fabric.

He stops.

SYSTEM POPUP:

Badge signal disconnected.

Please keep corporate identification visible at all times.

Repeated negligence may affect employee reliability score.

Reiji checks his coat. His pockets. His bag.

Nothing.

REIJI — spoken:

“No.”

REIJI — thought:

No badge meant no train. No apartment. No office. No proof that the city recognized him as a person.

Another message appears.

SYSTEM POPUP:

Lost signal timer: 08:41.

Biometric owner separation detected.

If signal exceeds 10:00, trace assistance will activate.

Reiji looks back toward the alley beside Neon Pub.

The rain thickens.

Scene 2 — The Alley

Background: Alley behind Neon Pub.

Ren sits on an overturned crate, holding Reiji's badge between two fingers.

He uses it to catch the neon light.

Blue.

Pink.

Blue again.

When he sees Reiji, he smiles.

REN — spoken:

"Looking for your soul, tower man?"

REN — thought:

Smile. Keep his eyes on your face, not the card. If the signal already pinged, security is close.

Reiji stops several steps away.

REIJI — spoken:

"That's mine."

REIJI — thought:

Stay calm. Desperation gives people leverage.

Ren studies the card.

REN — spoken:

"Funny. It says you belong to Nakamura Neural Systems."

REN — thought:

Whole life on a plastic square. That's the joke.

Reiji extends his hand.

REIJI — spoken:

"Give it back."

Ren flips the badge once and catches it.

REN — spoken:

"This opens trains, doors, elevators, clean toilets... maybe vending machines that don't spit at you."

REIJI — spoken:

"You can't use it. Biometric lock."

REN — spoken:

“Can’t use it well. Different thing.”

The badge vibrates in Ren’s hand.

A red dot blinks near the corner.

SYSTEM AUDIO FROM BADGE:

Owner separation: 09:22.

Trace assistance pending.

Ren’s smile thins.

Only for a moment.

REN — thought:

Door for him. Beacon for me.

Reiji hears the audio too.

He looks toward the mouth of the alley.

Two security drones slide under the highway.

A temporary checkpoint is unfolding near the subway entrance.

Three officers.

Two drones.

One portable scanner gate.

CHECKPOINT DISPLAY:

Routine identity verification.

Thank you for supporting urban safety.

Ren holds the badge out.

REN — spoken:

“Here.”

Reiji takes it.

The badge reconnects instantly.

SYSTEM POPUP:

Corporate ID restored.

Please proceed to approved transit route.

Reiji looks at the checkpoint.

Then at Ren.

Ren has already stepped back.

REN — spoken:

“Good. You’re a person again.”

REN — thought:

Don’t wait for help. People don’t offer. Move first.

The nearest drone turns toward the alley.

Blue scanner light slides across the rain.

Choice — What does Reiji do?

Option 1 — Help Ren immediately

Variable suggestion:

```
trust += 1  
projection -= 1  
liability += 1
```

Reiji steps forward before he can make the action reasonable.

REIJI — spoken:

“Walk with me.”

REIJI — thought:

Do it before you turn it into a theory and kill it.

Ren looks at him.

REN — spoken:

“What?”

REN — thought:

Trap? Mistake? Pity? Don’t look grateful.

REIJI — spoken:

“You found my badge. You’re returning it. That’s all.”

Ren studies his face.

Then the drone light reaches the alley wall.

Decision becomes smaller.

Less noble.

More immediate.

Ren walks beside him.

They approach the checkpoint together.

The scanner reads Reiji.

Green.

Then Ren.

Yellow.

The officer looks at Ren's wet jacket.

SECURITY OFFICER — spoken:

"He with you?"

Reiji lifts his badge.

REIJI — spoken:

"Yes. He found my corporate ID. I'm taking him to file a witness note."

REIJI — thought:

Administrative language. The safest kind of lie.

The officer glances at the growing line behind them.

Then at the rain.

Then at the yellow scanner result.

SECURITY OFFICER — spoken:

"Temporary witness transit. Commercial lanes only."

The gate opens.

As they pass through, Reiji's wrist display vibrates.

SYSTEM POPUP:

Host-linked irregular transit recorded.

Reliability review: minor.

Ren waits until the scanner is behind them.

REN — spoken:

“Witness note?”

REN — thought:

He lied fast. Not perfectly. Fast enough.

REIJI — spoken:

“It sounded official.”

Ren almost smiles.

REN — spoken:

“Careful. You’re better at crime than you look.”

Jump to: **After the Checkpoint**

Option 2 — Ask for the truth first

Variable suggestion:

`masking += 1`

`trust -= 1`

Reiji keeps the badge in his hand.

REIJI — spoken:

“Why did you return it?”

Ren stares at him.

The drone light grows brighter.

REN — spoken:

“Bad resale value.”

REN — thought:

Not now. Not here. Why do tower people need reasons before they move?

Reiji does not step forward.

REIJI — spoken:

“That’s not the whole reason.”

Ren’s smile sharpens.

REN — spoken:

“You want honesty? It was a door for you and a tracking flare for me.”

The badge timer vanishes from Reiji’s screen.

A scanner tone replaces it.

DRONE AUDIO:

Unregistered presence probability: 71%.

Secondary scan required.

Ren looks at the drone.

Then at Reiji.

REN — spoken:

“Satisfied?”

Reiji moves.

Too late to make it look instinctive.

REIJI — spoken:

“He’s with me.”

The officer turns.

SECURITY OFFICER — spoken:

“Purpose?”

Reiji lifts his badge.

REIJI — spoken:

“He recovered my corporate ID. I’m filing a witness note.”

The scanner washes over Ren.

Yellow.

Yellow.

A brief red flicker.

Ren sees it.

So does Reiji.

The officer enters something into his tablet.

SECURITY OFFICER — spoken:

“Temporary witness transit approved. Subject marked for route compliance.”

The gate opens.

Reiji’s wrist display vibrates.

SYSTEM POPUP:

Host-linked irregular transit recorded.
Witness claim pending.
Reliability review: moderate.

Ren walks through without looking at him.

Only when they are inside the station does he speak.

REN — spoken:

“You always ask people to explain themselves while the knife is coming down?”

REIJI — spoken:

“I needed to know.”

REN — thought:

No. You needed to feel clean.

Jump to: **After the Checkpoint**

Option 3 — Keep walking, then turn back

Variable suggestion:

```
trust -= 2  
noise += 1  
liability += 2
```

Reiji steps toward the checkpoint alone.

His badge scans green before he reaches the gate.

The officer barely looks at him.

Behind him, Ren moves toward the side lane.

The drone follows.

DRONE AUDIO:

Please present valid registration.

Reiji keeps walking.

The gate opens.

Warm station air touches his face.

Then he hears the scanner tone.

Not yellow.

Red.

DRONE AUDIO:

Unregistered subject flagged.

Remain still for civic transfer.

Reiji stops.

Ren stands under the drone light with both hands raised.

Still smiling.

Badly.

REN — spoken:

“Must be a system error.”

REN — thought:

Fence too far. Officer left. Lens low. Kick and run if they touch the shoulder.

Reiji looks at the subway gates.

Open.

Clean.

Safe.

Then he looks at Ren’s shoes.

Still wet.

Still ready to run.

Reiji turns back.

REIJI — spoken:

“He’s with me.”

The officer looks annoyed.

SECURITY OFFICER — spoken:

“You just passed alone.”

Reiji swallows.

REIJI — spoken:

“He returned my corporate ID. I failed to register the witness properly.”

REIJI — thought:

Use their language. Make the lie sound like paperwork.

The officer studies him.

Then points to the tablet.

SECURITY OFFICER — spoken:

“Host liability. Sign.”

A form appears on Reiji’s wrist display.

SYSTEM POPUP:

Temporary Host Liability Agreement.

You accept responsibility for the unregistered contact’s movement within authorized commercial and residential corridors.

Failure to comply may affect housing wellness score.

Reiji presses accept.

The gate opens.

Ren walks through slowly.

He does not thank him.

He does not joke.

Inside the station, he keeps one full step of distance.

REN — spoken:

“Nice of you to come back.”

REN — thought:

Remember that he left first.

Jump to: **After the Checkpoint**

After the Checkpoint

Background: Subway station interior.

The station is bright, dry, and controlled.

That makes Ren look even more out of place.

His shoes leave dirty water on the polished floor. His eyes keep moving: cameras, exits, officers, maintenance doors.

Reiji notices how quickly Ren reads the space.

Not like a tourist.

Like someone measuring how long a cage takes to close.

A station announcement chimes.

STATION ANNOUNCEMENT:

Line 7 delayed due to weather-related track inspection.

Estimated delay: twenty-eight minutes.

Ren looks up.

REN — spoken:

“Twenty-eight minutes in a bright room full of cameras. Romantic.”

REN — thought:

Too long. Too exposed.

Another announcement follows.

STATION ANNOUNCEMENT:

Unauthorized sheltering in transit areas is prohibited.

Please report unattended persons or unregistered sleeping.

Both of them hear the word.

Sheltering.

More officers enter from the upper stairs.

Reiji looks at Ren.

Then at the residential exit.

His apartment is close.

Small.

Sterile.

Locked.

Dry.

REIJI — spoken:

“My apartment is close.”

Ren's face changes.

Not much.

Enough.

REN — thought:

There it is. Price. There's always a price.

REN — spoken:

"Congratulations."

Reiji winces.

REIJI — spoken:

"You can wait there until the checkpoint clears."

REIJI — thought:

Make it practical. Practical is less frightening than kindness.

Ren studies him.

REN — spoken:

"You invite strangers home often?"

REIJI — spoken:

"No."

REIJI — thought:

I barely invite myself there.

Ren almost smiles.

Then another drone passes overhead.

The scanner light brushes the floor near his feet.

Choice becomes less philosophical.

Ren pulls his jacket tighter.

REN — spoken:

"Fine. But I'm not thanking you."

REIJI — spoken:

"I didn't ask."

They walk toward the residential gate.

Reiji scans his badge.

Green.

For Ren, the gate stays closed.

A menu appears on Reiji's wrist display.

SYSTEM POPUP:

Temporary guest authorization requested.

Purpose of visit?

OPTIONS:

Family

Corporate associate

Service worker

Medical support

Other

Reiji selects:

Other.

The system pauses.

Longer than it should.

SYSTEM POPUP:

Guest authorization approved for two hours.

Host liability acknowledged.

Guest movement restricted to registered residential unit.

Unauthorized extension may affect housing wellness score.

The gate opens.

Ren steps through.

REN — spoken:

“Host liability. Cute.”

REN — thought:

Even kindness comes with paperwork.

Scene 3 — Residential Elevator

Background: Residential elevator.

The elevator rises through the corporate housing tower.

Outside the glass wall, Tokyo drops beneath them.

Neon Pub becomes a bright wound under the highway.

The checkpoint becomes a small blue dot in the rain.

Ren watches the city shrink.

REN — spoken:

“Must be nice.”

REN — thought:

Don’t sound jealous. Make it casual.

Reiji looks at him.

REIJI — spoken:

“What?”

Ren keeps looking through the glass.

REN — spoken:

“Being above the rain.”

Reiji does not answer.

REIJI — thought:

He thinks height means escape.

The elevator chimes.

SYSTEM AUDIO:

Residential level forty-two.

Nakamura Neural Systems employee housing.

Please keep guests within approved zones.

The doors open.

A white corridor stretches ahead.

No trash.

No graffiti.

No smell except filtered air and cleaning solvent.

Ren steps out carefully, as if the floor might reject him.

At the end of the corridor, Reiji’s apartment waits behind a white corporate door.

Reiji places his palm against the scanner.

SYSTEM POPUP:

Resident confirmed.

Welcome back, Morikawa Reiji.

Today's wellness compliance: incomplete.

The door unlocks.

Dim yellow light spills into the hallway.

Small room.

Narrow bed.

Desk.

Kitchenette.

Window full of neon rain.

For Reiji, it is barely a home.

For Ren, it is almost impossible.

Ren steps inside.

The door closes behind them with a soft corporate chime.

End of Act II.

14.4 Act III — Apartment Conversation

Scene 1 — Inside Reiji's Apartment

Background: Reiji's apartment. 2:00 AM.

The door closes behind them with a soft corporate chime.

For a moment, the room is silent.

Not peaceful.

Sealed.

Reiji's apartment is small: one narrow bed, one desk, a kitchenette, and a window filled with neon rain. Charging cables hang beside the sink like black veins. The walls are clean, but not warm. Everything feels assigned, measured, and temporary.

Ren stands near the entrance, still dripping rainwater onto the floor.

He looks around.

Door. Lock. Bed. Electricity. Ceiling.

A room that does not leak.

He tries not to look impressed.

REN — spoken:

“So this is where they store you?”

REN — thought:

A real room. Don't stare. Don't make it obvious.

Reiji takes off his coat. The wall hook scans it and begins drying it automatically.

SYSTEM POPUP:

Moisture detected.

Drying cycle initiated.

Resident stress level: elevated.

Reiji closes the popup.

REIJI — spoken:

“It's just corporate housing.”

REIJI — thought:

Say “just” before he can call it privilege.

Ren looks at the ceiling.

REN — spoken:

“You people say ‘just’ about rooms with roofs.”

REN — thought:

Make it a joke before it sounds like envy.

Reiji fills two cups of water and gives one to Ren.

Ren drinks too quickly, then stops himself.

Reiji pretends not to notice.

Choice — What does Reiji do first?

Option 1 — Offer Ren dry clothes

Variable suggestion:

trust += 1

projection -= 1

Reiji opens the drawer under the bed.

Inside are folded shirts, all the same color, all the same cut.

Corporate casual wear.

He takes one out and holds it toward Ren.

REIJI — spoken:

“You should change. Your jacket is soaked.”

REIJI — thought:

This is easier than asking if he is cold.

Ren looks at the shirt.

Then at Reiji.

REN — spoken:

“You always hand strangers uniforms?”

REN — thought:

Take it. Don't look relieved. Just take it.

He takes the shirt.

A few minutes later, he comes back wearing it under his jacket. The shoulders do not fit him right.

He looks warmer.

He also looks annoyed that Reiji can see it.

REN — spoken:

“Don't laugh.”

REIJI — spoken:

“I wasn't going to.”

REN — thought:

Good. Because I might keep it.

Option 2 — Do nothing

Variable suggestion:

masking += 1

noise += 1

Reiji stands by the kitchenette with both cups in his hands.

He should offer something.

Clothes.

A towel.

A chair.

Anything.

Instead, he waits for the correct sentence to appear.

It does not.

Ren remains near the door, dripping onto the floor.

REN — spoken:

“Relax. I won’t stain the property value.”

REN — thought:

Should’ve stayed under the bridge. At least the bridge doesn’t pretend to think.

Reiji puts one cup on the desk.

REIJI — spoken:

“You can sit.”

Ren looks at the chair.

Then at the door.

REN — spoken:

“Maybe.”

He does not sit.

The room becomes colder without the temperature changing.

Option 3 — Question him about the badge

Variable suggestion:

trust -= 1

masking += 1

Reiji keeps standing.

The badge rests against his chest again.

Safe.

Recovered.

He touches it once without meaning to.

Ren notices.

REN — spoken:

“You checking if I stole it twice?”

REIJI — spoken:

“I’m trying to understand why you returned it.”

REIJI — thought:

If I can explain the action, I do not have to feel grateful.

Ren’s expression closes.

REN — spoken:

“I told you. It was burning a hole in my hand.”

REIJI — spoken:

“That isn’t an answer.”

REN — thought:

He still wants a clean reason. Even here.

Ren steps closer.

REN — spoken:

“You want the honest version? I thought about using it. I thought about selling it. Then it started calling security to my hand.”

He points at Reiji’s chest.

REN — spoken:

“So congratulations. Your life is too dangerous to steal.”

Reiji has no clean answer to that.

Scene 2 — The Desk

Rain taps against the window.

The guest authorization timer glows faintly on the wall panel.

SYSTEM POPUP:

Guest authorization remaining: 01:42:18.

Ren sees the timer.

He says nothing.

Instead, his attention shifts to Reiji's desk.

There are two monitors, a corporate terminal, several sealed data cartridges, and a broken neural adapter lying beside a cup of untouched instant coffee.

Ren steps toward it.

Reiji stiffens.

REIJI — spoken:

"Don't touch that."

Ren stops with one finger already on the adapter.

REN — spoken:

"This?"

REN — thought:

Broken shell. Loose port. Easy fix.

REIJI — spoken:

"It's work equipment."

REN — spoken:

"It's dead equipment."

He turns it over.

A red light flashes on the wall panel.

SYSTEM POPUP:

Unauthorized handling detected.

Unregistered guest interacting with restricted device.

Report incident?

Reiji crosses the room and takes the adapter from Ren's hand.

Too quickly.

Ren raises both hands.

REN — spoken:

“Sorry. Didn’t know broken trash had rights.”

REN — thought:

There it is. The door. The rank. The invisible line.

Reiji looks at the wall panel.

The options remain:

REPORT

DISMISS

EXTEND SCAN

His thumb hovers.

Then he selects:

DISMISS.

SYSTEM POPUP:

Incident dismissed.

Resident discretion recorded.

Ren watches him.

REN — spoken:

“You get recorded for not reporting me?”

REIJI — spoken:

“Everything gets recorded.”

Ren looks around the room again.

Door scanner.

Wall panel.

Drying hook.

Sleep monitor built into the bed frame.

Window sealed shut.

REN — spoken:

“Your door opens only when the company recognizes your hand.”

Reiji says nothing.

Ren points to the window.

REN — spoken:

“Your window doesn’t open.”

Then the bed.

REN — spoken:

“Your bed reports your sleep.”

A pause.

REN — spoken:

“You sure this is a room?”

Reiji looks at the apartment.

He has lived here for three years.

He has never had to describe it.

REIJI — spoken:

“It’s safe.”

REIJI — thought:

That was the answer the system would accept.

Ren gives a short laugh.

No humor in it.

REN — spoken:

“Safe from what?”

Reiji looks at the broken adapter in his hand.

At the company logo.

At Ren’s bare wrist.

No badge.

No registration.

No green light.

REIJI — spoken:

“From being outside.”

Ren’s face changes.

Not much.

Enough.

REN — spoken:

“Yeah.”

REN — thought:

He does know. A little.

Scene 3 — The Broken Device

Ren reaches into his jacket and takes out the broken holographic koi projector from the alley.

It is cracked, wet, and barely alive.

He places it on the desk beside Reiji’s neural adapter.

REIJI — spoken:

“You kept that?”

REN — spoken:

“Of course. It’s almost useful.”

REIJI — thought:

Almost useful. That sounded like a prayer in this city.

Ren picks up a small tool from Reiji’s desk.

This time, he waits.

Reiji looks at the tool.

Then at Ren.

Then at the wall panel.

No warning yet.

REIJI — spoken:

“Careful.”

REN — spoken:

“That your permission or your anxiety?”

REIJI — spoken:

“Both.”

Ren smirks.

He opens the projector casing with quick, practiced fingers. He removes a bent connector, strips a wire with his teeth, and borrows a contact pin from the broken adapter.

Reiji watches despite himself.

Ren's hands are fast.

Not careless.

Not uneducated.

Trained by necessity instead of school.

A spark jumps.

The projector flickers.

For half a second, a broken blue koi swims across Reiji's desk.

Then the light bends.

The koi stabilizes.

Small.

Dim.

Alive.

Ren leans back.

REN — spoken:

"See? It just needed someone to stop treating it like trash."

REN — thought:

Don't make that about yourself. Too late.

The koi swims through the air above the desk.

Its light passes over Reiji's face.

He has no response ready.

REIJI — spoken:

"You fixed it."

REN — spoken:

"Don't sound so shocked."

REIJI — thought:

I was.

The projector hums softly.

The room feels less empty with one impossible fish moving through it.

Scene 4 — Work, Identity, Sleep

Ren finally sits on the chair.

Not relaxed.

Just less prepared to bolt.

Reiji sits on the edge of the bed.

The distance between them is small.

It still feels like a checkpoint.

REN — spoken:

“So what do you actually do, Morikawa Reiji?”

REN — thought:

Say the full name. Remind him he has one.

Reiji looks at the corporate terminal.

REIJI — spoken:

“I work on transit-identity integration. Badge scanners. Wellness sync. Access authorization.”

Ren looks at the door.

Then back at him.

REN — spoken:

“So doors.”

REIJI — spoken:

“Systems.”

REN — spoken:

“Doors with better vocabulary.”

Reiji almost smiles.

Almost.

REIJI — spoken:

“They’re supposed to keep people safe.”

REN — spoken:

“People?”

The word lands harder than the sentence.

Reiji does not answer quickly enough.

Ren looks away first.

REN — spoken:

“Never mind.”

REN — thought:

Don’t ask him where you fit. You know the answer.

The wall panel chimes.

SYSTEM POPUP:

Rest window recommended.

Sleep recovery projected: 58%.

Guest presence may reduce recovery quality.

Ren reads it upside down.

REN — spoken:

“Your bed complains about visitors?”

REIJI — spoken:

“It complains about me too.”

Ren looks at him.

A small silence.

The first one that does not feel hostile.

REN — spoken:

“You sleep here every night?”

REIJI — spoken:

“Yes.”

REN — spoken:

“And you still look like that?”

Reiji looks at the bed.

Narrow.

Clean.

Waiting.

REIJI — spoken:

“I don’t sleep much.”

REIJI — thought:

Having a bed and being able to rest were apparently separate privileges.

Ren leans back in the chair.

His body still faces the door.

Ready to move.

Ready to run.

REIJI — spoken:

“Do you?”

Ren shrugs.

REN — spoken:

“Sure. Stairs. Tunnels. Market roofs. Anywhere if you’re tired enough.”

REN — thought:

Never deep. Never both eyes closed. Never when footsteps slow down near you.

Reiji notices Ren’s posture.

Chair angled toward the exit.

Feet planted.

Hands free.

He realizes Ren has not stopped preparing to leave since entering the room.

REIJI — spoken:

“I thought you were free.”

Ren opens one eye.

REN — spoken:

“Yeah?”

REIJI — spoken:

“Outside the pub. You looked less trapped.”

Ren looks at the sealed window.

Then at Reiji's badge.

REN — spoken:

"You looked safe."

The koi swims once around the desk lamp.

Blue light.

Rain.

A room that is both shelter and cage.

Neither of them says what they have just understood.

Scene 5 — The Timer

The apartment clock changes to 02:17.

SYSTEM POPUP:

Guest authorization remaining: 00:57:03.

The timer glows between them.

A reminder that even shelter has an expiration date.

Ren looks at it.

REN — spoken:

"When the timer ends, don't renew it."

Reiji looks at him.

REIJI — spoken:

"Why?"

Ren smiles faintly.

REN — spoken:

"Because then this becomes a thing."

REIJI — spoken:

"A thing?"

REN — spoken:

"A place I know I can come back to."

His smile stays.

His voice does not.

REN — spoken:

“That’s dangerous.”

REN — thought:

Wanting a door is worse than sleeping in rain.

Reiji says nothing.

After a moment, he reaches toward the wall panel.

He does not renew the authorization.

He does not terminate it.

He only dims the screen until the timer disappears.

SYSTEM POPUP:

Display muted.

The room becomes darker.

The city becomes louder.

Ren pulls the blanket around his shoulders.

If Reiji offered clothes earlier, the borrowed shirt is visible beneath it.

If Reiji did nothing earlier, Ren keeps his wet jacket on.

If Reiji questioned the badge earlier, Ren sits farther from the bed.

The koi projector continues to glow on the desk.

Small.

Unapproved.

Not reported.

Reiji lies back without sleeping.

Ren closes his eyes without trusting the room.

Neither of them is safe.

But for a few minutes, neither of them is alone.

End of Act III.

14.5 Act IV — One Month Later

Opening

Black screen.

A soft electronic chime.

Then another.

Then another.

The sound becomes an alarm.

TEXT ON SCREEN:

One month later.

Sequence 1 — Reiji: Morning

Background: Reiji's apartment. 7:30 AM.

The apartment is pale with artificial morning light.

Reiji opens his eyes before the alarm finishes.

SYSTEM POPUP:

Wake cycle complete.

Sleep recovery: 61%.

Recommended mood correction: mild.

He sits up.

For a second, he looks toward the chair.

Empty.

The blanket is folded over the back.

If Reiji offered Ren clothes, the drawer under the bed is still missing one shirt.

If Reiji did nothing, there is still a faint water stain near the door.

If Reiji questioned Ren about the badge, the chair is pushed farther from the bed than Reiji remembers.

Reiji looks at the room.

Nothing has changed.

That is what makes it worse.

REIJI — spoken:

“Right.”

REIJI — thought:

Of course he left. People without keys learn not to wait for doors.

Quick cut.

Reiji puts on his coat.

Quick cut.

His badge clips into place.

Quick cut.

The apartment door opens.

SYSTEM POPUP:

Resident departure recorded.

Productivity forecast: stable.

The door closes.

Sequence 2 — Transit

Background: Subway platform.

The station is crowded.

No one speaks.

Commuters stand in clean lines beneath flickering advertisements. Their badges blink softly against dark coats. A train arrives with perfect timing.

NEWS TICKER:

Tokyo Corridor productivity reaches new monthly high.

Across the tracks, security officers check a man's wristband.

Yellow scan.

Then red.

The man lowers his head.

The crowd adjusts around the scene without looking at it directly.

The train doors open.

Reiji steps inside.

REIJI — thought:

A month ago, I would have looked away faster.

The train pulls away.

The platform disappears.

Sequence 3 — Reiji: Office

Background: Nakamura Neural Systems office.

Rows of desks.

Rows of screens.

Rows of faces lit from below.

Reiji sits before a corporate dashboard.

WORK TERMINAL:

Transit-identity anomaly review.

Guest access irregularity report.

Lower-sector movement correlation.

He scrolls.

Most cases are numbers.

Badge mismatch.

Expired wristband.

Unauthorized shelter density.

Then one line stops him.

WORK TERMINAL:

Case cluster: temporary guest access abuse.

Associated resident class: corporate housing.

Associated movement: lower-sector transit evasion.

Recommended response: restrict shelter loopholes.

Reiji scrolls again.

A map appears.

Neon Pub.

Shinjuku Corporate Exchange.

Residential Tower 42.

Lower market sectors.

Bridge underpass.

Sumida River pedestrian bank.

His own guest authorization record is not named.

It does not need to be.

The path is enough.

REIJI — spoken:

“No.”

REIJI — thought:

The system had taken a door he opened once and turned it into a map.

A supervisor passes behind him.

SUPERVISOR — spoken:

“Patch queue by noon, Morikawa.”

SUPERVISOR — thought:

Quiet one. Reliable. Good.

Reiji closes the report.

Then opens it again.

Sequence 4 — Ren: Lower Market

Background: illegal lower market. Evening.

Ren sits at a folding repair table beneath a leaking tarp.

Broken displays.

Burnt wires.

Old speakers.

A cracked toy fish projector.

He repairs a small screen for a woman selling steamed buns from a metal cart.

The screen flickers back to life.

A blue koi swims across it.

The woman smiles.

MARKET AUNTIE — spoken:

“You should open a stall, Ren.”

MARKET AUNTIE — thought:

If he lives long enough to save rent.

Ren grins.

REN — spoken:

“Working on my empire.”

REN — thought:

One table. One roof. One place they can’t kick over before breakfast.

A security siren sounds from the upper stairwell.

The market changes instantly.

No screaming.

No panic.

Just motion.

Hands fold cloth.

Boxes vanish.

Lights go out.

People disappear into alleys they already knew.

Ren grabs his tools and the broken koi projector.

Too slow.

A drone drops into the lane.

DRONE AUDIO:

Unauthorized commercial activity detected.
Please remain visible for civic assistance.

Ren runs.

Not dramatically.

Practically.

Fast enough to survive.

Quiet enough not to be worth chasing.

Sequence 5 — Reiji: Cafeteria

Background: corporate cafeteria. Noon.

Reiji sits alone with a meal tray.

Two coworkers speak nearby.

COWORKER 1 — spoken:

“Line 7 got delayed again. Some unregistered guy tried sleeping near the gates.”

COWORKER 2 — spoken:

“They should clear those sectors permanently.”

Light laughter.

Disposable chopsticks.

Filtered water.

Routine.

Reiji grips his cup.

REIJI — spoken:

“Clear them where?”

The coworkers look at him.

A small silence opens.

COWORKER 1 — spoken:

“What?”

Reiji releases the cup.

REIJI — spoken:

“Nothing.”

REIJI — thought:

There it is. Speak, then retreat before the sentence becomes a position.

The lunch break ends.

Everyone returns to work.

The system records full attendance.

Sequence 6 — Ren: Underpass

Background: bridge underpass. Night.

Rain falls through cracks in the concrete.

Ren reaches the underpass carrying his tools in one hand and the koi projector in the other.

He stops.

His sleeping spot is gone.

Metal barriers seal the dry corner beneath the bridge. Yellow corporate tape stretches across the concrete.

NOTICE:

Urban sanitation zone.

Temporary obstruction removed.

Public safety restored.

Ren stares at the sign.

Behind the barrier, his old blanket is soaked in a puddle.

A plastic bag of spare parts lies torn open.

The koi projector slips in his hand.

For a moment, he does not move.

Then he laughs.

Quietly.

Badly.

REN — spoken:

“Public safety.”

REN — thought:

They cleaned the place where no one was allowed to exist.

A drone voice echoes from the street above.

DRONE AUDIO:

Please avoid restricted shelter zones.

Ren backs away from the barrier.

The borrowed corporate shirt is visible beneath his jacket.

Less clean now.

Still there.

He pulls the jacket closed over it.

REN — thought:

Don't ruin it. Stupid. It's just a shirt.

The rain gets heavier.

He turns toward the river.

Sequence 7 — Parallel Routine

Quick cuts.

Reiji's apartment.

Reiji wakes.

Lower market.

Ren bargains.

Subway train.

Reiji stands among silent commuters.

Transit tunnel.

Ren sleeps sitting up.

Corporate office.

Reiji reviews calibration errors.

Black-market repair table.

Ren fixes a cracked display.

Apartment.

Reiji deletes a wellness notification.

Alley.

Ren jokes with strangers he does not trust.

News screen.

NEWS:

Consumer confidence rising.

Office screen.

SYSTEM:

Productivity stable.

Security screen.

SECURITY REPORT:

Unauthorized shelter density reduced by 18%.

Apartment window.

Reiji watches rain hit the glass.

Bridge underpass.

Ren watches the same rain hit the river.

The cuts slow.

Sequence 8 — Reiji Notices

Background: Reiji's office. Late evening.

Most desks are empty.

Reiji remains at his terminal.

The guest-access report is still open.

A new update appears.

WORK TERMINAL:

Temporary shelter loopholes closed.

Unauthorized guest-access abuse linked to lower-sector movement.

Additional route restrictions recommended.

A map redraws itself.

Several red zones disappear.

Market access.

Tunnel access.

Bridge underpass access.

One route remains faintly open.

Sumida River pedestrian bank.

Reiji stares at it.

His wrist display vibrates.

SYSTEM POPUP:

Wellness recommendation: evening walk.

Nearest low-density route: Sumida River pedestrian bank.

Estimated stress reduction: 9%.

He almost dismisses it.

Then he stops.

For no logical reason, he thinks of Ren.

Not as freedom.

Not as danger.

Not as a problem the city failed to solve.

As a person who had sat in his apartment, soaked and cold, pretending not to want a place to return to.

Reiji stands.

SUPERVISOR — spoken:

“Morikawa? Leaving?”

Reiji picks up his coat.

REIJI — spoken:

“Yes.”

REIJI — thought:

For once, the answer arrives before the reason.

Sequence 9 — Ren Notices

Background: riverside service path.

Ren walks under the elevated road.

His tools are gone except for one screwdriver.

The koi projector is cracked again.

A security checkpoint unfolds at the market entrance behind him.

No way back.

He reaches into his jacket pocket and finds an old corporate badge he picked from a trash bin earlier.

Not Reiji's.

Different name.

Different face.

Same plastic authority.

He turns it over.

The chip is dead.

Useless.

REN — spoken:

“Bad resale value.”

REN — thought:

He would have corrected the technical reason.

Ren smiles despite himself.

The smile fades quickly.

A siren sounds behind him.

He drops the badge into the river.

It lands without ceremony.

The water swallows it.

Sequence 10 — End of Montage

Background: Reiji's apartment corridor. Night.

Reiji walks toward the elevator.

The corridor is clean.

Too clean.

His wrist display glows.

SYSTEM POPUP:

Resident departure recorded.

Weather advisory: heavy rain.

Recommended route confirmed: Sumida River pedestrian bank.

The elevator descends.

Outside the glass wall, Tokyo rises around him.

Neon towers.

Silent trains.

Billboards smiling into rain.

REIJI — thought:

I am not looking for him.

The elevator passes another floor.

Then another.

REIJI — thought:

I am just going outside.

The doors open.

Rain fills the soundscape.

Final Cut

Background: Sumida River pedestrian bank.

Ren stands near the rusted railing.

Not over it.

Not yet.

Just close enough that the city lights break around his outline.

Above him, Tokyo shines.

Below him, the river carries broken neon in long, trembling lines.

The rain has soaked through his jacket.

The borrowed shirt clings beneath it.

He holds the cracked koi projector in one hand.

It flickers once.

A small blue fish appears.

Then disappears.

Ren does not try to fix it.

He only watches the black water below.

Cut back to Reiji.

He steps onto the river path.

The city noise dulls behind him.

Ahead, through the rain, he sees a figure by the railing.

He stops.

REIJI — spoken:

“Ren?”

Ren does not turn around.

TEXT ON SCREEN:

Act V — Rainy Riverbank

End of Act IV.

14.6 Act V — Rainy Riverbank

Scene 1 — The River

Background: Rainy riverbank. Late night.

The rain turns the river black.

Neon from the corporate towers breaks across the water in long, trembling lines. Red. Blue. Gold. Then nothing. Then red again.

Reiji walks along the concrete floodwall with his collar raised.

The city is quieter here.

Not peaceful.

Just farther away.

Above the river, a train crosses the bridge. Its windows are full of pale faces, all moving somewhere approved.

Below it, the pedestrian path is cracked, wet, and almost empty.

Then Reiji sees him.

Ren stands near the rusted railing, one hand resting on the metal, looking down at the water.

His jacket is soaked.

The borrowed shirt is visible beneath it.

Reiji stops.

REIJI — thought:

I am not surprised. That is what frightens me.

Ren does not turn around.

REN — spoken:

“You’re bad at not looking for people.”

REN — thought:

Don’t sound relieved.

Reiji steps closer.

Not too close.

REIJI — spoken:

“I was walking.”

REIJI — thought:

A technically true sentence. The worst kind.

Ren laughs softly.

REN — spoken:

“Corporate wellness sent you to the saddest river in Tokyo?”

REN — thought:

Please don’t ask what I’m doing here.

For a moment, they listen to the rain.

Scene 2 — No Next Place

Reiji looks at the railing.

Then at Ren’s hand.

There are small cuts across his knuckles. One looks fresh. Another has the pale shine of a scanner burn.

REIJI — spoken:

“What happened?”

Ren shrugs.

REN — spoken:

“They closed Kanda tunnel.”

REIJI — spoken:

“Where did people go?”

Ren smiles without looking at him.

REN — spoken:

“You still ask questions like answers are waiting somewhere.”

A train passes overhead.

The bridge roars.

When the sound fades, Ren continues.

REN — spoken:

“Market’s gone too. Not gone-gone. Just folded into places even I don’t know.”

REN — thought:

Say it like trivia. Not like losing another roof.

Reiji looks toward the city.

REIJI — spoken:

“The report said temporary obstruction removed from river maintenance zones.”

Ren finally turns his head slightly.

REN — spoken:

“That what I was?”

Reiji has no answer.

The river keeps moving below them.

REN — spoken:

“Your gate remembered me.”

Reiji looks at him.

REN — spoken:

“After that night. More scanners went yellow. Then some went red. One drone even called me a prior guest-access anomaly.”

He gives a small laugh.

REN — spoken:

“Sounds fancy, right?”

REN — thought:

It means run earlier.

Reiji looks down.

Rain runs from his hair to his collar.

REIJI — spoken:

“I didn’t know it would do that.”

Ren nods.

Not forgiving.

Not accusing.

Just tired.

REN — spoken:

“That’s the trick, right?”

A pause.

REN — spoken:

“Nobody knows. The system just happens.”

Reiji looks at his badge.

Still glowing.

Still warm.

Still recognizing him.

REIJI — thought:

I wrote systems that happened to people.

Scene 3 — Recognition

Ren turns back toward the river.

His hand stays on the railing.

REN — spoken:

“You know what’s funny?”

REIJI — spoken:

“No.”

REN — spoken:

“Yours glows when it sees you.”

He points at Reiji’s badge.

Then taps his own chest.

REN — spoken:

“Mine would scream.”

Reiji takes the badge from his coat.

The clip resists slightly.

Then comes loose.

He holds it in his hand instead of wearing it.

For the first time, the front of his coat is blank.

Ren notices.

He does not comment.

That makes it matter more.

REIJI — spoken:

“I thought you were free.”

Ren closes his eyes.

Not surprised.

REN — spoken:

“You said that before.”

REIJI — spoken:

“I know.”

REIJI — thought:

I keep saying it because I am ashamed of how much I wanted it to be true.

Ren’s fingers tighten on the railing.

REN — spoken:

“And I thought you were safe.”

Reiji looks up at the towers.

His office is somewhere inside that light.

His apartment too.

His whole life, stacked vertically above the rain.

REIJI — spoken:

“I am safer than you.”

Ren does not argue.

That matters.

REIJI — spoken:

“But I don’t think safe is the same as alive.”

Ren looks down at the black water.

REN — spoken:

“No.”

A pause.

REN — spoken:

“But unsafe gets old fast.”

Neither of them smiles.

Scene 4 — The System Interrupts

Reiji’s wrist display vibrates.

The sound is small.

Too clean for the rain.

SYSTEM POPUP:

Unregistered contact detected.

Prior guest authorization expired.

Report contact for civic assistance?

Options appear on the screen.

REPORT

NO RECORD

Reiji looks at the popup.

Then at Ren.

Ren has seen it too.

His expression does not change.

That is worse than fear.

REN — spoken:

“Go on.”

REN — thought:

Let the room close. Let the door be honest this time.

Reiji’s thumb hovers over the display.

The rain runs across the glass.

For a second, neither option registers his touch.

Then Reiji selects:

NO RECORD

The screen pauses.

SYSTEM POPUP:

Action may affect reliability score.

Confirm?

Reiji presses confirm.

The popup disappears.

No alarm.

No drone.

Only rain.

Ren looks at him for a long moment.

REN — spoken:

“That was stupid.”

REIJI — spoken:

“Yes.”

REN — thought:

Thank you. Don't say thank you.

Reiji lowers his wrist.

The city continues shining behind them.

Final Choice — What does Reiji say?

Option 1 — “Come back.”

Variable suggestion:

```
trust += 1  
projection -= 1  
ending_push = "quiet_survival"
```

Reiji looks at the river.

Then at Ren's hand on the railing.

REIJI — spoken:

“Come back.”

Ren’s expression tightens.

REN — spoken:

“To your room?”

REIJI — spoken:

“Not because it fixes anything.”

A pause.

REIJI — spoken:

“Just because tonight is too long to stand here alone.”

Ren looks away.

His fingers do not leave the railing yet.

But they loosen.

Jump to Ending A — Quiet Survival.

Option 2 — “I’m sorry.”

Variable suggestion:

```
projection -= 1  
ending_push = "reflection"
```

Reiji does not step closer.

He does not offer a solution.

For once, he does not turn guilt into an explanation.

REIJI — spoken:

“I’m sorry.”

Ren waits.

As if expecting the rest.

There is no rest.

REN — spoken:

“For what?”

Reiji looks at the towers.

Then at the river.

Then at Ren.

REIJI — spoken:

“For thinking I understood what you were.”

Ren’s smile is faint.

Almost invisible.

REN — spoken:

“That’s not useless.”

The rain grows heavier.

Ren’s hand remains on the railing.

But his grip softens.

Jump to Ending B — Reflection.

Option 3 — Say nothing.

Variable suggestion:

`masking += 1`

`trust -= 1`

`ending_push = "city_continues"`

Reiji opens his mouth.

Nothing comes.

No clean sentence.

No safe sentence.

No sentence that does not sound like a report, an excuse, or a delayed apology.

Ren watches him understand that.

REN — spoken:

“Yeah.”

He turns back toward the river.

Above them, the news screen across the water brightens.

NEWS SCREEN:

Tokyo Corridor Economic Confidence Reaches Record High.

The words reflect in the river.

Then break apart.

Reiji stands beside him in the rain.

Still close.

Still too late.

Jump to Ending C — City Continues.

End of Act V.

14.7 Ending A — Quiet Survival

Condition suggestion:

`trust >= 2` and `projection <= 0`

Background: Rainy riverbank.

Ren's fingers loosen from the railing.

Not all at once.

One finger first.

Then another.

The movement is small enough that the city would never record it.

Reiji sees it.

He says nothing.

That is the first correct thing he does.

Rain runs down Ren's hair, his face, his jacket. The borrowed shirt beneath it is stained and stretched, no longer corporate-clean.

Ren looks down at it.

REN — spoken:

"Your shirt's ruined."

REN — thought:

I tried not to ruin it.

Reiji looks at the shirt.

Then at Ren.

REIJI — spoken:

“It looked worse in the drawer.”

Ren stares at him.

Then gives a short laugh.

Not bright.

Not easy.

But real.

REN — spoken:

“That may be the worst compliment I’ve ever received.”

The river moves below them.

Across the water, a news screen brightens through the rain.

NEWS SCREEN:

Tokyo Corridor Economic Confidence Reaches Record High.

Animated graphs climb cleanly upward.

Ren watches them.

REN — spoken:

“Looks like everyone’s doing fine.”

REN — thought:

If the numbers get high enough, maybe no one has to look down.

Reiji watches the same screen.

REIJI — spoken:

“They only count what keeps the lights on.”

Ren wipes rain from his eyes.

REN — spoken:

“And what helps them sleep.”

A pause.

Reiji looks at the black water.

Then back at him.

REIJI — spoken:

“Do you?”

Ren does not answer immediately.

Above them, the first early train crosses the bridge. Its windows are filled with pale faces, half-awake, already moving toward work.

REN — spoken:

“Sometimes.”

REN — thought:

Less now.

Reiji nods.

REIJI — spoken:

“Me too.”

Neither of them explains which part is true.

Ren finally steps away from the railing.

The scene changes because he does.

Not enough to save the city.

Enough to move one body away from the edge.

He looks toward the station.

Then toward the lower streets.

Then back at Reiji.

REN — spoken:

“So. You going back up there?”

Reiji looks at the towers.

His apartment is somewhere inside them: dry, sealed, assigned, waiting.

His badge is still in his hand.

Not on his coat.

A message glows across his wrist display.

SYSTEM POPUP:

Recommended return route: Residential Tower 42.
Weather exposure risk increasing.
Confirm route?

Reiji looks at the options.

Then closes the screen.

REIJI — spoken:

“Not yet.”

Ren tilts his head.

REN — spoken:

“That a decision or a malfunction?”

REIJI — spoken:

“Probably both.”

Ren almost smiles.

He starts walking along the riverbank.

After a few steps, he looks back.

REN — spoken:

“You coming, tower man?”

REN — thought:

Ask like it doesn't matter. Let him answer like it does.

Reiji follows.

They do not walk toward a solution.

They do not walk toward a changed city.

They only walk away from the railing.

Behind them, the news screen keeps shining.

NEWS SCREEN:

PRODUCTIVITY UP.
PUBLIC SATISFACTION STABLE.
UNAUTHORIZED POPULATION REDUCED.

The river reflects each word.

Then breaks it apart.

Final image:

The first train crosses above them.

For once, neither of them looks up.

End.

14.8 Ending B — Reflection

Condition suggestion:

trust moderate, noise high

Background: Rainy riverbank.

Ren does not step away from the railing.

Reiji does not ask him to.

The rain grows heavier.

It falls on the river, on the cracked concrete, on the rusted metal beneath Ren's hand. It falls on Reiji's clean coat until the fabric loses its corporate shape.

For a while, they stand side by side.

Not close enough to become comfort.

Close enough to become refusal.

Across the water, the towers shine with impossible confidence.

NEWS SCREEN:

Tokyo Corridor Economic Confidence Reaches Record High.

Ren watches the headline.

REN — spoken:

"You think they believe it?"

REIJI — spoken:

"Who?"

REN — spoken:

"The people who write those."

Reiji looks at the rising graphs.

The smiling officials.

The clean numbers.

REIJI — spoken:

“I think believing it is part of the job.”

Ren nods faintly.

REN — spoken:

“Sounds like your kind of job.”

Reiji almost smiles.

Almost.

REIJI — spoken:

“It was.”

A train passes above them.

For several seconds, the bridge roars.

When the sound fades, Ren is still there.

His hand is still on the railing.

But his grip is softer.

Reiji notices.

This time, he does not turn the observation into a conclusion.

REN — spoken:

“You should go home.”

Reiji looks toward the towers.

The word home moves through him and finds no place to settle.

REIJI — spoken:

“I don’t think I’ve been doing that.”

Ren turns his head.

For once, no joke arrives first.

REN — spoken:

“What?”

REIJI — spoken:

“Going home.”

A pause.

REIJI — spoken:

“I’ve been returning to a room.”

Ren looks away first.

The river catches a red advertisement and stretches it until the word becomes unreadable.

REN — spoken:

“Careful. You’re starting to sound like someone who thinks too much.”

REIJI — spoken:

“I already was.”

REN — spoken:

“Then think quieter.”

The line should be funny.

It is not.

Reiji wants to offer the apartment.

The chair.

The water.

The blanket.

The locked door.

The bed that reports sleep.

Every clean offer now sounds like another form of permission.

So he says only:

REIJI — spoken:

“I can stay.”

Ren closes his eyes.

REN — thought:

Don’t make me need that.

REN — spoken:

“For how long?”

Reiji answers without improving the truth.

REIJI — spoken:

“I don’t know.”

The rain fills the space where certainty should go.

Slowly, the camera moves away from them.

First their faces disappear.

Then their bodies.

Then only the railing remains.

Then only the river.

Neon trembles across the black water.

Red.

Blue.

Gold.

Then broken dark.

REIJI — thought:

I used to think the city was bright because it was alive.

A pause.

REIJI — thought:

Now I think it shines because it is afraid of what would appear in the dark.

The water carries the light downstream.

The image fades before we know whether Ren steps back.

Final image:

The river, reflecting a city that cannot see itself.

End.

14.9 Ending C — City Continues

Condition suggestion:

trust <= 0 or masking >= 2

Background: Rainy riverbank.

Reiji says nothing.

No apology.

No offer.

No wrong sentence.

No right one.

Only rain.

Ren waits for a moment.

Then stops waiting.

REN — spoken:

“Yeah.”

He turns back toward the river.

The word is small.

It does not accuse.

That makes it worse.

Reiji looks at his wrist display.

The screen is dark now.

No record.

No report.

No proof.

For one second, he thinks that might matter.

Then the city answers before either of them can.

Across the river, a news screen expands to full brightness.

NEWS SCREEN:

Tokyo Corridor Economic Confidence Reaches Record High.

The headline repeats.

Then splits into smaller headlines.

NEWS SCREEN:

PRODUCTIVITY UP.

PUBLIC SATISFACTION STABLE.

TRANSIT FLOW IMPROVED.

UNAUTHORIZED POPULATION REDUCED.

Behind the words, animated graphs rise.

Clean.

Green.

Certain.

Ren looks at Reiji.

Then at the river.

Then at the towers.

REN — spoken:

“You know this doesn’t change anything.”

Reiji nods.

REIJI — spoken:

“I know.”

Ren studies him.

REN — spoken:

“No. I mean really.”

He gestures toward the towers.

REN — spoken:

“You can feel bad. You can press the nicer button. You can stand in the rain and look like you understand.”

A pause.

His voice stays level.

REN — spoken:

“Tomorrow your gate still opens.”

Reiji looks down.

His badge glows faintly in his hand.

Even unworn, it knows him.

Ren looks back at the river.

REN — spoken:

“And mine still doesn’t.”

The rain hardens.

A security drone passes far above them, too high to care.

The scanner light does not touch the riverbank.

Not yet.

Reiji opens his mouth.

This time, a sentence comes.

REIJI — spoken:

“I’m sorry.”

Ren does not turn.

REN — spoken:

“I know.”

The answer is not forgiveness.

It is not anger.

It is only exhaustion.

The camera cuts to the news screen.

NEWS SCREEN:

Tokyo Corridor Economic Confidence Reaches Record High.

The audio from the city swells.

Train announcements.

Corporate jingles.

Weather advisories.

Morning schedules.

Productivity alerts.

A public service message begins.

ANNOUNCEMENT:

Thank you for supporting a safer, cleaner, more efficient Tokyo Corridor.

The camera cuts back to the riverbank.

Reiji stands alone in the rain.

Or almost alone.

The railing is wet.

The river is black.

The city light breaks across the water and reforms itself immediately.

Reiji's wrist display vibrates.

SYSTEM POPUP:

Weather exposure risk elevated.

Recommended route: Residential Tower 42.

Confirm return?

Reiji does not press anything.

The popup remains.

The news continues.

NEWS SCREEN:

PUBLIC SATISFACTION STABLE.

Cut to black.

The corporate jingle plays once.

Clean.

Soft.

Perfectly timed.

End.